PEACE MAGAZINE

Project Save The World's NEWSLETTER

October ~ December 2026





People's Nonviolent Resistance for Peace

World Social Forum on the Road

- The Global Hunger Crisis
- AI Weapons: dangerously close
- The Mental Toll of Displacement

GENUINE CANADIAN MAGAZINE



NEWSWORTHY

DESALINATION PLANTS AFFECTED BY ALGAE

Israel has faced an unprecedented environmental crisis: a sudden, massive algae bloom—about 100 km in length—in the Mediterranean Sea forced the shutdown of five out of six desalination plants last month. The country's water supply has now been restored and is running at about 50% of capacity, with increased water being pumped from the Sea of Galilee.

The Israel Water Authority and Mekorot Water Company continue to provide reduced water supplies to farmers in the south, while residents have maintained about 99% of their normal water use. Additionally, Israel temporarily halted the supply of water to the Gaza Strip, impacting hundreds of thousands of people who are already suffering from a severe water shortage.

Scientists speculate that increased temperatures may be causing the unusual high-seas algae bloom, which appears to originate in the NileDelta and move northward to Israel's Mediterranean coast. The destruction of sewage treatment infrastructure in Gaza may also be a contributing factor.

Check out the September 17th BBC report at: https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/ck4glvqj4qqdo.

UN FRAMEWORK CONVENTION ON INTERNATIONAL TAX COOPERATION

The fifth session of UN discussions on this framework wrapped up on 13 August 2026. The International Negotiating Committee began work in early 2025 and is now preparing a draft text to be submitted to the General Assembly in the fall of 2027.

This UN framework examines tax parity between developed and developing countries. It aims to regulate tax-related illicit financial flows, institute taxation of cross-border services, and increase transparency around tax havens. The core mission of the Framework Convention is to reform global tax rules to give low- and middle-income countries a greater voice and to combat illicit financial flows.

The zero draft is to be completed before the final submission to the General Assembly next year, and members are now actively discussing revisions to the text.

A CANADIAN PEACE MUSEUM

Three years ago, a group of peace advocates working in Toronto agreed that Canada needed a peace museum. They decided to avoid government red tape and set it up as a non-profit organization. They argued that there is a war museum but not a peace museum. Through artifacts, visitors and especially children could develop attitudes and behaviour that help them become peacebuilders.

The museum opened with great fanfare on September 21st, this year's International Peace Day. The four founding directors were present: Chris Houston, an international humanitarian worker; Sara Wolfe, an Anishnawbe innovator, impact investor, and organizer; Dr. Oyedeji Ayonrinde, director of the Museum of Health Care in Kingston; and Linda Kalafatide, a retired teacher and peace activist.

The Canadian Peace Museum was gifted by the North Hastings Community Trust and is an 8,000-square-foot, two-floor industrial complex with sufficient space for exhibits, a library, and archival storage. At the front of the building there is a large community hall that already has welcoming décor. This space is used or rented for book launches, nonviolent communication workshops, community events, training on peace and nonviolence, and similar activities.

Securing funding for the construction and opening of the museum has not been easy. A combination of small donations and volunteer labour for renovations has been crucial in getting the main parts of the building completed on time, supplemented by support from a few larger donors.

Even though Bancroft seems far-flung and not located on a well-traveled tourist track (250 kms from Toronto) the founders believe that the Canadian Peace Museum will engage with Ontario's rural and Indigenous populations as well as urban residents from Toronto, Kingston, and Hamilton. The management team hopes the museum will be deeply rooted in the local community while also connecting with the broader Canadian public. In the longer term, the vision is to expand international networking as well.

The core message of the Canadian Peace Museum is not only to recall past events but to consider how to cultivate a culture of peace in today's world—what Martin Luther King Jr. called "positive peace, in which all persons will respect the dignity and worth of human personality."

See https://canadianpeacemuseum.ca/ ■

PEACE MAGAZINE

October - December, 2026 Vol. XLII No. 4



Together we will | Довидович Михаил, Adobe Stock

2 **Newsworthy**

4 **Masthead, editorial**

5 **Letters**

6 **World Social Forum on the Road:** *is this a new formation?*
By Jill Carr-Harris

11 **The Necessity for a Vast Pleistocene Park**
By John Bacher

14 **Dangerously Close:** *AI Weapons and the UN's Efforts to Govern Them*
By Paulina Chan

17 **The Global Hunger Crisis**
By Dalia Al-Awqati and Diana Sarosi

21 **The Hidden Mental Toll of Afghan Refugee Displacement**
By Mehrullah Rahman

23 **When Slow isn't Safe:** *Canada's Climate Report*
By Metta Spencer and AI

27 **Youth Column:** *Peace and Family are for Everyone*
By Roger Kitsvi

31 **AI Sentiment is Rising**
By Alan Heirach (with the assistance of AI)

35 **Inclusion vs. Equity, Vol. 4:** *Common Unity in the Face of Climate Change*
Reviewer: Girish G Patil

38 **Crossing into Canada:** *Stories from Two Generations of US War Resisters*
Reviewer: Stephen Harold Riggens

40 **Project Save the World's Summer 2026 Online Forum**
A directory of URLs to our recent video conferences with experts

Peace Magazine and Project Save the World are "open forums"

places where expert discussions of life-threatening global Issues are made freely accessible.

You can share well-reasoned, evidence-based knowledge, including responses to *Peace Magazine* articles and our video forums.



We invite your informed, relevant discussion. Our moderators watch the website andremove inappropriate posts and personal rudeness.

peace MAGAZINE

BOARD OF DIRECTORS • Lloyd Axworthy • Sue Dick • Gordon Edwards • Hilal Elver • John Feffer • Mary Kaldor • Adam Koniuszewski • David Miller • P.V. Rajagopal • Metta Spencer • Ronald St. John • Peter Wadhams • Alyn Ware • Paul Werbos

HONORARY PATRONS • Douglas Roche • Frank Sommers

GUEST-EDITOR • Jill Carr-Harris

ASSOCIATE EDITORS, THIS ISSUE • Sue Dick • Michaela Ehring • Subir Guin • Stephen Harold Riggins • Olivia Ward • Adam Wynne

BUSINESS OFFICE • P. O. Box 248, Toronto P, Toronto. M5S 2S7, Telephone: 437/887-6978. Email: office@peacemagazine.org

EDITORIAL OFFICE • E-mail: mspencer@web.net
• Web: www.peacemagazine.org.

FRONT COVER • World Social Forum's publicity images

BACK COVER • Saim, Adobe Stock

OUR WEBSITES • peacemagazine.org • tosavetheworld.ca

SUBSTACK • ProjectSaveTheWorld

SUBSCRIPTIONS

Peace Magazine is now the official quarterly newsletter of Project Save the World. We send free digital copies to thousands of organizations worldwide that are working to prevent these global catastrophes: war and weapons; global warming; famine and water shortage; pandemics; radioactive contamination; cyber risks; and threats in the economy; governance and human rights; and civil society. If your organization wishes to receive this newsletter regularly, just send us its email address.

And you can still subscribe for digital editions only: $19.99 per year, globally, to read on any computer or smart phone; available only through PressReader. On your computer or cell phone, log in to PressReader. Then in "search publications," type in Peace Magazine to see subscription and credit card options.

Indexed in Canadian Index (Proquest/Micromedia) and the Alternative Press Index (US), and our website: peacemagazine.org. Print copies of most of our back issues are available at $4.50 each plus postage.

Peace Magazine (ISSN 0826-9521) is published four times a year by Project Save the World. Mail can be sent to Box 248, Toronto P, Toronto M5S 2S8. Advertising, single copy sales, and editorial enquiries should also be sent to this address.

Project Save the World's only officially endorsed positions are stated in the "Platform for Survival" shown on our website, tosavetheworld.ca. Because we are an open forum, views expressed by contributors do not represent the opinion of Project Save the World or this newsletter, *Peace Magazine*. Editorial or pictorial content may be reproduced in any medium, provided that reprints are prominently credited and that copies of any reprinted materials are forwarded to us. We assume no responsibility for unsolicited materials. However, we encourage readers to submit articles, notices, photos, and art — but no poetry or fiction please.

We maintain electronic and paper records at our offices. A data protection statement is available on the *Peace Magazine* website at www.peacemagazine.org or on request.

Publications Mail Agreement No. PM40065350
Return undeliverable Canadian addresses to:
PO Box 248, Station P, Toronto ON M5S 2S7
email: mspencer@web.net

From the Editor

This year's theme of the UN General Assembly was "Restoring Trust, Managing Transformation: A UN that Delivers for All." In his final speech, outgoing Secretary-General António Guterres reiterated the current challenges of active wars, climate chaos, inequality, runaway technology, and the AI gap. He called for a "reformed" UN with much greater capacity to manage such existential threats.

In response, the Partners for Multilateralism (P4M), consisting of Barbados, India, Australia, Canada, Kenya, Finland, Brazil, and the EU, viewed UN reform as a means of institutionalizing international cooperation. This was intended to counter those member states threatening UN funding and its survival. They reiterated that such coalitions would be able to get things done.

African leaders, such as the President of Kenya, William Ruto, brought the full weight of 54 African member states into the governance discussion—with a plan to secure two Security Council seats—to uphold international law as a necessary foundation for building African sovereignty and fairer global governance.

These are two examples that illustrate the pushback against forces weakening the UN and international cooperation in favour of power politics.

However, international cooperation is not relegated solely to governments and the UN. NGOs also work tirelessly to reduce large-scale conflicts and promote peace, especially at the local and community levels. Some of the tools they employ include building people's participation through dialogue and nonviolent strategic resistance.

As seen on the cover, the recent World Social Forum in Cotonou, Benin, was an exercise in forging international cooperation. African leaders engaged in nonviolent struggle that foregrounded alternative perspectives and programs for a more peaceful future. They did this by leading a mega-movement: organizing cross-continental caravans, mobilizing hundreds of local leaders across 22 Sahelian and Central African nations, and bringing together 10,000 participants at the university venue in Cotonou before the beginning of the World Social Forum.

For three days, civil society actors and local leaders deliberated on policy issues related to social and gender inequality, environmental and climate destruction, runaway AI, and both genuine and hybrid wars and conflicts. They raised concerns about human security and opportunities for peacebuilding, even as the Benin government tried—unsuccessfully—to close the event.

Through nonviolent resistance, people from across Africa, along with a cross-section of international civil society, raised their voices on some of the significant causes of conflict plaguing our societies.

These same issues were reflected in the speeches of the 130 members of the UN General Assembly. International cooperation is necessary to address these challenges. ■

By Guest Editor, Jill Carr-Harris

Our Readers Write PEACE

NORMALIZED VIOLATIONS OF INTERNATIONAL LAW

High-Level Week of the UN General Assembly is underway in New York, offering opportunities for leaders to defend the international rule of law.

Violations of international law are not new. But they have grown more frequent and more normalised in recent years and, ironically, are carried out by the very powers supposed to be its chief guarantors, as permanent members of the UN Security Council. Each violation of international law emboldens others. Knowing that there is no credible referee, the unacceptable becomes normal.

The rule of law is often dismissed as an abstract or technical subject, or even a colonial legacy. This is not the case. Such narratives only make it easier for autocrats to dismiss it, especially at a time of geopolitical tension.

We regret that public skepticism about international cooperation is rising. People need to recognize what the international rule of law and its institutions deliver. They provide indispensable global public goods in multiple areas – for international peace and security, public health, communications and transportation, and the environment, among many others. They make our everyday lives safer and more predictable. Dismiss them and the most vulnerable will pay the highest price.

The world now faces multiple existential threats: nuclear weapons, the climate and nature crisis, pandemics and poorly regulated artificial intelligence. No country can tackle these challenges alone. The rule of law is the framework that makes cooperation possible.

This is why The Elders are launching a new campaign on international rule of law. We will defend those who champion it, challenge the 'might-is-right' narrative and push for concrete institutional reforms.

We urge everyone attending this UNGA to speak with one voice that rights must be respected, and those who abuse them must be held to account. A stronger, fairer, more consistent rule of law is vital to overcome our greatest threats and protect our fundamental freedoms.

Ernesto Zedillo Ponce de León
Former President of Mexico
The Elders Foundation
3 Tilney Street,
London W1K 1BJ
www.theelders.org

NATIONAL DAY FOR TRUTH AND RECONCILIATION

Tragically, human beings can sometimes be treated as disposable, their suffering and deaths devalued even by otherwise democratic nations. We see this reprehensible apathy in our response to protracted wars and famines, where the loss of life warrants only meagre column inches on the back pages of First World news.

This immoral devaluation is often fueled by prejudice, making it easier for a conscience to ignore the suffering of those who look different.

In Canada, this history of treating Indigenous peoples as disposable is starkly evident in the forced-attendance residential school system.

No one should ever be treated like garbage. Yet, in the heartbreaking case of murdered and missing Indigenous women in Manitoba, victims with their remains were dumped in a Winnipeg landfill.

It is a profound failure of conscience when we allow differences in appearance or background to diminish our shared humanity.

Frank Sterle Jr.
White Rock, B.C. V4B 4B5

AN UNPUBLISHED REMARK BY GORBACHEV

I came across of the old Gorbachev's short interview that I have translated for you. It was done in 1999-2000.

Translation:

"Has Putin demonstrated any remarkable abilities? What, did he show how to run some big corporation? Did he show how to lead a region? Is he a man with extensive experience? Does he think he's Russia's savior? Nothing of the sort; he fell on us like a stone from a mountain, and totally unknown to anybody.

"Well, listen, what's his background? He represented the State Security Committee in the GDR, then served as Sobchak's assistant. That's all his experience. He himself was surprised when he was appointed to lead the Federal Security Service.

"He even refused the rank of general because he felt unworthy of it. But since he was appointed prime minister, or rather, given a different appointment, his sense of caution has disappeared. He decided he was needed.

"Yeltsin's staff thought he was the man who could, so to speak, lead them away from what was feeding the fears of the entire system, of this entire entourage, who should have gone with Yeltsin. But nothing of the kind. By means of Putin, they continued to exist.

"And they seem to be ridding themselves of their fear. I think it's hopeless. Putin, Putin, Putin.

"If he continues to pursue what he's pursued so far, he's doomed. And we are doomed with him. And that means there will be some very, very drastic outcomes."

Alexander Likhotal
Geneva, Switzerland
Providence, R. I.

World Social Forum on the Road: Is this a new formation?

By Jill Carr-Harris



African leaders discussing follow up actions

The Road to Cotonou: How Nonviolent Caravans Redefined the World Social Forum

By early August 2026, the roads leading into Cotonou, Benin, had become unlikely frontlines in a new experiment in global civil society. Long caravans of buses and jeeps—carrying farmers, women's groups, youth activists and land defenders— inched toward the coastal city, only to be met by police blockades on the border.

Inside Cotonou, there were about 10,000 people from 80 countries waiting for the buses to arrive on August 4th so that they could begin the inauguration of the World Social Forum. The government used bureaucratic stonewalling to stop this symbolic convergence from happening.

Among them, a 10-member Indian delegation representing Ekta Parishad and the Peacebuilders Forum had traveled to Benin alongside partners from RRAS Africa, Home for Humanity and the Mahatma Gandhi Canadian Foundation. Their mission was ambitious: not only to participate in the WSF, but to help transform the gathering into a "Peace Factory"—a space to train and galvanize young peacebuilders from across Africa and beyond.

They arrived to find a civil society gathering under siege—and a rare, quiet victory for nonviolent resistance in the making. and what would become a defining moment for the World Social Forum (WSF). In this circumstance the first-ever Peace Forum took shape.

A FORUM ON THE ROAD

Since 2001, the World Social Forum has presented itself as a counterweight to the World Economic Forum, bringing together movements and organizations that fight inequality, land grabbing, climate injustice and corporate power. Yet in recent years, critics charged that the WSF had become a periodic talking shop, removed from the daily realities of those it promised to represent.

African activists decided to do something about that.

For more than a decade, organizers had floated the idea of a "WSF on the road"—a roving forum of caravans that would criss-cross countries, listening to communities and gathering testimonies before culminating in the main event. In 2026, they finally did it.

The model drew on earlier experiments across Mali and the wider Sahel, where activists had organized "Convergence of Land and Water Struggles" caravans in response to land grabs, water privatization and climate shocks. Those efforts had been small and local. By 2026 they had grown into something far larger: a Global Convergence of Land, Water and Indigenous Seeds.

Traveling over two weeks across 22 countries, the caravans stopped in rural villages and urban neighborhoods to visit agroecological farms, hold public forums, meet local officials and document stories often absent from development reports: forced displacement, coastal erosion, seed privatization, contaminated water, shrinking farmland, and the slow erasure of indigenous ways of life.

The caravans were, in effect, moving classrooms and town halls—part political education, part organizing tool, part act of visibility for people who rarely see themselves reflected in global summit halls.

For Ekta Parishad, the Indian land-rights movement long associated with Gandhian foot-marches, this method felt familiar. In 2024 they had led a "Gandhi to Buddha" cross-border march and bus caravan from India to Nepal's WSF in Kathmandu, insisting that nonviolent public pressure remains essential for social justice. The African caravans, they believed, were a natural extension of that philosophy.

What nobody had fully anticipated was how strongly governments in the region would react.

WHEN NONVIOLENCE MEETS SECURITY STATES

Benin, host to the 2026 WSF, became the flashpoint. Its government with an Interior Minister known for quashing a coup attempt in late 2025, watched as buses filled with mobilized activists rolled toward its borders. State security systems, built to confront armed insurgents and jihadist groups, were poorly equipped to respond to an explicitly nonviolent movement that traveled openly, held public meetings and broadcast its agenda.

The reflex was to block.

At both the western border with Togo and the eastern frontier with Nigeria, border police units stopped the caravans. Vehicles were held up for days. Dozens of participants in Benin who had come from various countries were deported without clear explanation. Benin's largest public university, Université d'Abomey-Calavi, was suddenly denied permission to host the WSF, leaving more than 5,000 registrants with no formal venue.

Inside the blockaded buses, however, conflict did not escalate. Instead, it slowed down.

Participants from across West and Central Africa turned the border stands into impromptu forums—running workshops, cultural exchanges, strategy meetings. They discussed land rights, women's leadership, agroecology, and peacebuilding, all within sight of heavily armed security forces. The images and stories trickled through local networks and social media, even as official communications from the Benin WSF Organizing Committee all but collapsed under governmental pressure and its own internal weaknesses.

At one point, after finally allowing the buses to cross from Togo, some officials ordered them turned back again, deepening confusion inside the government and sharpening the moral contrast: an apparently indecisive state against calm, disciplined caravans



Caravan buses arrive on August 6th to inaugurate the WSF event

committed to nonviolence.

It was, for many observers, a textbook case of how nonviolent resistance can work under pressure. "Governments understand how to fight guns," one participant remarked during the Forum. "They don't know what to do with songs, stories and patient determination."

Eventually, authorities relented. Seventeen buses rolled into Cotonou on August 6—two days after the WSF's scheduled opening—greeted with celebration. For those on board, the border ordeal was not just a delay; it became the political prelude to the Forum itself, a lived demonstration of what they came to discuss.

AFRICA STEPS FORWARD

Once in Cotonou, another story was quietly unfolding: a shift in who leads the global conversation.

African organizations, long marginalized in international civil society spaces, were the backbone of WSF 2026. Their leaders brought hard-won experience from conflict zones, climate frontlines and resource struggles. They also brought new assertiveness in how they engaged European partners—particularly senior members of the French NGOs, who have historically played a dominant role in the WSF's International Committee.

In a region still marked by French colonial and neo-colonial influence, the emergence of formations like the Alliance des États du Sahel (AES)—an economic and security bloc of Mali, Niger, Burkina Faso and Benin—has made relations with French actors more politically charged. Some African activists openly backed efforts to dismantle French economic dominance in the region. Many French NGOs chose a deliberately low profile in Cotonou, conscious of their country's legacy and the changing dynamics.

The result was a more complicated, sometimes tense, field of alliances. European solidarity, once taken for granted, was now being scrutinized. The Indian delegation, aware of these sensitivities, opted to remain neutral, prioritizing unity around nonviolence over taking sides in intra-movement geopolitics.



The tree symbolizes life in spite of 800,000 slaves leaving from this place in the Kingdom of Dahomey between 1727-1852

Despite the frictions, the Forum crackled with cross-border organizing.

There were Afro-Caribbean farmers from Haiti and Martinique—descendants of people enslaved and shipped out of Benin's ports between 1750 and the 1820s—now returning to West Africa as land-rights campaigners aligned with Via Campesina.

Women in Peacebuilding from Nigeria confronted deep questions about security architecture in a region scarred by Boko Haram and cross-border kidnappings, arguing that women must be integrated not just symbolically but structurally into security decision-making.

Women-led caravans from Mali and Burkina Faso, guided by figures like Aichata Koné, illustrated how land, water and seeds are inseparable from peace; control over resources determines whether communities can withstand climate and conflict shocks.

Delegations from DR Congo—migrants stranded in Morocco, youth resisting mining in the east, women survivors of violence tied to extractive industries—drew direct connections between global demand for minerals and local ecocide.

Algerian youth and women described fragile but tangible partnerships with their government around conflict resolution. South Asian participants from Nepal, Pakistan and India came in solidarity, linking Himalayan climate challenges and land struggles with those in the Sahel and Congo Basin.

The cumulative effect was a different center of gravity: a WSF no longer dominated by Latin American or European narratives, but increasingly shaped by African voices.

INSIDE THE PEACE FORUM

Within this wider ferment, the Peace Forum set out to do something specific: turn discussions on nonviolence into practical tools, especially for young people.

The Peace Forum was anchored by four organizations: RRAS Africa (the initiator, rooted in West Africa), Home for Humanity, the Mahatma Gandhi Canadian Foundation and Ekta Parishad. Their shared vision that the Peace Forum should be like a factory was less about a single event than about setting in motion processes that would continue in villages, universities and communities long after the WSF banners came down.

Unable to conduct the large-scale training they had originally envisaged, the coalition instead organized five intensive workshops—each a laboratory for rethinking peace from the ground up.

RECLAIMING CULTURAL WISDOM

The first workshop, led by Home for Humanity, tapped into local and indigenous traditions of conflict resolution. RRAS Burkina Faso presented examples where customary systems emphasize reconciliation and social harmony over punishment. Participants from Gandhi Gram University and Ekta Parishad linked this with Gandhian community approaches, while First Nations representatives from Canada—the Métis and Dene–Suline—described land-based learning, language revitalization and ceremonies once outlawed under colonial rule.

The message was clear: real peace must be rooted in place—its ecology, culture and memory—not imported wholesale from international handbooks.


One of the review meetings of the nonviolent resistance carried out

WOMEN AS AGENTS OF NONVIOLENCE

The second session focused on women's roles in peacebuilding, and the persistent tendency to treat gender-based violence as a "women's issue" rather than a structural one. RRAS facilitators brought in the framework of UN Security Council Resolution 1325, which mandates women's participation in peace and security processes. A male practitioner from DR Congo working on 1325 implementation, speaking from a war context, challenged male allies to take responsibility rather than outsource the work.

Participants experimented with re-framing gender not as a rigid binary but as interacting energies—drawing on Gandhian ideas of the "feminine" and "masculine" as coexisting forces.

Examples from Benin, Nigeria and Canada showed how women's leadership is reshaping village councils, refugee camp management and even urban classroom practice, where circle-based learning brings youth into spaces of shared responsibility and mutual care.

YOUTH ON THE FRONTLINES

The third workshop, facilitated by Ekta Parishad, gave the floor to young people whose biographies read like compressed versions of 21st-century turbulence.

One had grown up in an Indian urban slum, organizing peers around basic services and safety. Another came from a Nigerian refugee camp, where self-organized youth committees had emerged in the absence of effective state support. A Rwandan participant, shaped by the genocide, spoke of intergenerational dialogues to break cycles of trauma and revenge.


Opportunities for learning how to advocate nonviolently

A young Indian architect sketched out what a hospital would look like if designed around the needs of the poor, rather than private profit. A youth activist from a mining-affected region detailed campaigns to hold companies to account for environmental devastation.

What united them was a demand not simply to be "included" but to co-design the structures meant to govern their futures. The workshop ended with a call for stronger global networks of young peacebuilders, able to mentor, support and learn from each other between big summits.

RETHINKING THE ECONOMY, NONVIOLENTLY

The fourth session moved from the streets to the balance sheet: what does a nonviolent economy look like?

Participants examined community-based solar projects, drew lessons from the Japanese natural farming system Shizen Nōhō, and engaged with Gandhian economic principles that prioritize mutuality, cooperation and minimal harm to nature. Speakers from Zimbabwe, Nigeria and Egypt shared stories of enterprises that resist extractive models, grounding themselves instead in local ecosystems and knowledge.

From DR Congo came a stark reminder: the global economy of extraction—cobalt, coltan, gold—has a human cost borne by women, children and fragile environments. Nonviolence, the speakers argued, must extend from protest tactics to the core logic



African and Indian team coming together

of how resources are valued, extracted and used.

EDUCATING FOR "SLOW PEACE"

The final workshop turned to education as a long-term peace infrastructure. Gandhi Gram University showcased its model of higher education that requires students to live and work with marginalized communities, learning development work by doing it.

RRAS presented the University of Peace model in Africa, aimed at re-framing "security" in human and social terms. Canadian educators described "slow peace": a pedagogy that privileges deep relationships, patience and steady transformation over quick fixes. Nigerian participants spoke of efforts to keep girls in school as a strategy against both gender inequality and recruitment by armed groups.

Collectively, these workshops suggested that peace is less an event than a set of enduring practices—economic, cultural, educational—that need to be woven into daily life.

AFTER COTONOU: WHAT COMES NEXT

As the WSF ended, the Peace Forum convened African leaders and international allies for one last session. The border blockades, the fragile victory, the successful caravans and the improvised Peace Forum had opened space, but they had also underlined how fragile that space can be.

Several concrete follow-up commitments emerged:

- **Training future bridgebuilders:** Ekta Parishad will identify African students currently studying in India and expose them to nonviolence and community-based organizing, with the idea that they will return home as bridges between movements.
- **Ethical investment:** The Peacebuilders Forum plans to design "Nonviolent Economy" training for Indian companies investing in Africa, to prevent development projects from reproducing the very inequalities and conflicts they claim to address.
- **Village-level peace labs:** RRAS, which has already trained roughly 350 people from over 30 countries through the University of Peace, wants to launch village-level intervention programs in Africa. They have asked Indian practitioners to spend 6–12 months embedded in African communities, offering technical and educational support.
- **South–South activist exchanges:** The Global Convergence of Land and Water Struggles in West Africa (CGLTE-WA) proposed regular exchanges: ten activists from India to Africa and ten from Africa to India every year. The goal is mutual learning on land rights, rural organizing and nonviolent movement-building.

These proposals, still seeking funding and political space, amount to a quiet wager: that South–South solidarity and shared nonviolent practice can provide a counterweight to shrinking civic space and hardening state security attitudes worldwide.

If the events in Benin are any indication, future World Social Forums may increasingly happen not only in conference centers, but on the roads, fields and border crossings where global crises are already playing out.

The caravans to Cotonou were blocked, delayed, and harassed. They arrived late. But they arrived—transforming the WSF in the process. In an era of militarized politics and digital outrage, the spectacle of hundreds of activists waiting peacefully at a border, holding workshops under police watch, may seem almost anachronistic.

To those who were there, it felt like something else: the early days of a new kind of global movement, one that insists that peace is not a slogan, but a route you take—slowly, together, bus by bus. ■

Jill Carr-Harris is a teacher, trainer, researcher in the field of peace in both Canada and India.

PEACE
MAGAZINE

The Necessity for a Vast and Quickly Assembled Pleistocene Park

By John Bacher



Wrangel Island Musk Oxen

Usually ignored in climate change strategies is the urgent necessity for a Pleistocene Park, which would encompass most of the Arctic hemisphere. Here lies the world's biggest carbon sink: permafrost. It encompasses some 2.5 million square miles on land, with another similar-sized reservoir lying beneath the ocean floor.

The massive release of methane, carbon dioxide, and nitrous oxide—formerly trapped securely in permafrost until dangerous leaks and craters began to emerge in the 1960s—is one of the most unpredictable and frightening scenarios of anthropogenic climate change. The methane released by these growing holes in the ground is 25 times more powerful at trapping heat than carbon dioxide.

What has become known as the Batagaika Crater in the Sakha Republic of Eastern Siberia is an ominous 81-hectare hole in the permafrost, which has been expanding at a rate of 15 meters annually. It emerged as a result of deforestation; stripping the ground of shading trees increased ground temperatures and caused the permafrost to melt. During the time of its emergence, the crater was kept secret from the world through Soviet censorship and was only discovered through the interpretation of satellite imagery by scientists in democratic countries.

This massive, growing crater, often called the "Gateway to Hell," has exposed the remains of animals killed off by humans at the end of the Pleistocene era. Remains of extinct animals found here include the Woolly Mammoth, the Woolly Rhinoceros, and the Lena Horse, with its flesh and even blood intact. Musk Oxen skeletons have also been unearthed.

Musk Oxen were reintroduced from Canada to western Siberia in 1974. However, there had been no Musk Oxen in what is now the Sakha Republic since the species was extirpated through overhunting around 555 BC. They have now been restored to Pleistocene Park.

Musk Oxen were also restored to Wrangel Island, surrounded by the Arctic Ocean, from Canadian populations in 1975. Wrangel Island was the last refuge for the Woolly Mammoth before it was exterminated shortly after the arrival of human hunters armed with projectile spears around 2000 BC. This appears to have ended the debate over climate change versus human hunting as the primary cause of the Woolly Mammoth's extinction.

While originally sparked by clear-cutting over frozen land, the Batagaika Crater continues to expand because of global trends in climate change. Twenty other craters, created from explosions that ignite debris, have emerged over melting permafrost in other parts of Siberia. Most have appeared in areas of extensive petroleum exploration and development. Scientists believe this figure is disguised by some craters becoming lakes, which are also unleashing methane into the atmosphere.

The Republic of Sakha has experienced some of the most rapid temperature increases and highest rates of permafrost melt in the world. More worrisome than the Batagaika Crater is the loss of 10 to 11 square kilometers annually in Sakha from permafrost melt, causing ground subsidence on the shores of the Arctic Ocean.

The town closest to the Batagaika Crater, Chersky, displays some of the most dramatic demonstrations of permafrost melt. Its buildings are shaking and shifting from the sinking ground. Roads have caved in. Woolly Mammoth remains are frequently uncovered in the muddy, melting earth.

Since the Sakha Republic faces some of the worst consequences of melting permafrost, it is understandable and appropriate that it has inspired one of the most practical responses to this danger: the concept of Pleistocene Park. Its goal is to restore the full assemblage of mammals that thrived in the Pleistocene era. The decline of these mammals during the transition to the human-dominated Holocene era, alongside more recent declines in caribou populations, has reduced the insulation of packed snow on top of the permafrost. It has also increased temperatures that melt the permafrost due to a lack of intensifying herbivore grazing.

What is tragic today is that the judicious approach advocated by the Zimovs for the permafrost belt north of the Arctic Circle is not being followed by governments in Russia, the United States, and Canada.

In the words of the founder of the 160-square-kilometer nature sanctuary, Sergey Zimov, expressed in the prestigious peer-reviewed journal Science, the goal of Pleistocene Park is to repair the damage caused by humans in the Holocene era. Zimov wrote that it "stands to reason that the landscapes" of the Pleistocene "can be reconstituted by the judicious return of the appropriate herbivore community." This is what Zimov and his son, Nikita, have been doing since 1988 at what was then the Soviet-era Northeast Science Station.

The first actions by the Zimovs were to increase the populations of existing moose and caribou herbivores, whose numbers had been diminished by a post-Soviet plague of poaching. They also introduced hardy, domestic Yakutian horses to substitute for the ecological impacts of the exterminated Lena Horse. Musk Oxen were restored from other Siberian populations, most notably and successfully from the Putorana Nature Reserve. Pleistocene Park is protected by a 600-square-kilometer buffer zone administered by the Republic of Sakha, which safeguards it from the impacts of industrial exploitation. These efforts have successfully lowered temperatures above the permafrost by two degrees Celsius.

The Zimovs currently have bulldozers stand in for the vanished Woolly Mammoth, which had the capability to knock down trees to create a more biologically diverse ecosystem. They hope that if efforts to genetically modify Indian Elephants to survive the Arctic cold succeed, they will eventually be released into Pleistocene Park.

What is tragic today is that the judicious approach advocated by the Zimovs for the permafrost belt north of the Arctic Circle is not being followed by governments in Russia, the United States, and Canada. The only large areas of permafrost where significant numbers of Musk Oxen and caribou can cool the earth are the domains of the still-mighty Porcupine and Taimyr caribou herds. These lands represent only a small percentage of the threatened terrestrial permafrost belt.

In Russia, the only stronghold of a great caribou herd that can still hard-pack snow on a large scale through vast migrations is the Taimyr herd. Its protected area is now the core of the world's largest caribou herd, numbering 600,000 animals. Likewise, the Porcupine Caribou herd, which straddles Alaska and the Yukon, has shown stability within historic fluctuation limits, hovering between 120,000 and 180,000 caribou, despite slight recent declines. Like the range of the flourishing Taimyr herd, the positive impact of herbivore grazing on the permafrost here has been bolstered by the successful restoration of Musk Oxen.

Outside the well-protected ranges of the Taimyr and Porcupine herds, previously large herds impacting the tundra and taiga landscapes in Russia, the United States, and Canada have precipitously collapsed. Some of the most dramatic demises have occurred in Canada. One example is the George River Caribou herd, whose protection from low-level flying military aircraft was, for a decade, a key goal of the Canadian peace movement. Military aircraft eventually stopped flying over the herd's massive range—which encompasses the eastern half of Ungava, straddling Quebec and Newfoundland and Labrador—because they posed a danger to planes flying for mineral exploration.

However, the consequences of this exploration and related massive road construction, such as the Trans-Labrador Highway (which was blocked by a massive caribou herd shortly after it was built), have led to the collapse of the George River herd. The massive Voisey's Bay nickel mine was built on a critical calving ground. The herd's population, which was 800,000 in 2001, has plunged to a current level of just 7,200 caribou. Similar catastrophic collapses have impacted previously massive migrating herds like the Bluenose-East, Bluenose-West, and Bathurst caribou, triggered by a massive increase in gold and diamond mining and associated roads in their ranges.

The future of the Porcupine Caribou herd was impacted immediately by an Executive Order from re-elected American President Donald Trump upon returning to office. While this action has been delayed through litigation and the disinterest of oil companies concerned about their reputations, a recent travel section of the New York Times is instructive. It urged readers to visit the Arctic National Wildlife Refuge, which encompasses much of the herd's range, before it is despoiled by oil drilling. In the past, Canadian governments protested loudly against American efforts to drill for oil here, but they have been silenced on this issue by the deluge of tariff attacks on Canada by the Trump administration.

Soon after securing his election, Prime Minister Mark Carney announced massive road construction projects through the heart of the ranges of collapsed caribou herds in the mainland regions of the Northwest Territories. These include the Mackenzie Valley Highway, the Grays Bay Road, and the Arctic Economic Security Corridor, all of which will make recovery efforts to resurrect declining caribou herds much more challenging.

One of the most dramatic, high-profile initiatives that defies the logic of Pleistocene Park is the opening up of the National Petroleum Reserve in Alaska—bordering the western range of the Porcupine Caribou herd—for oil drilling. Here, the Willow Project is being designed for oil drilling utilizing thermosiphons, a technology developed to protect petroleum infrastructure in areas of permafrost melt. Called a "carbon bomb," it is expected to spew out 287 million tonnes of greenhouse gas emissions.

The outgoing US Presidential Administration of Democratic President Joe Biden approved the Willow Project despite massive opposition. ■

John Bacher is an environmental activist in St. Catharines, Ontario.

GLOBAL TOWN HALL

On the last Sunday of every month
Project Save the World
welcomes you
to a Zoom discussion
with activists around the world.



2:00–4:00 pm
Eastern time
zoom.us
We edit the recording and post it later where you can discuss it on our website:
tosavetheworld.ca

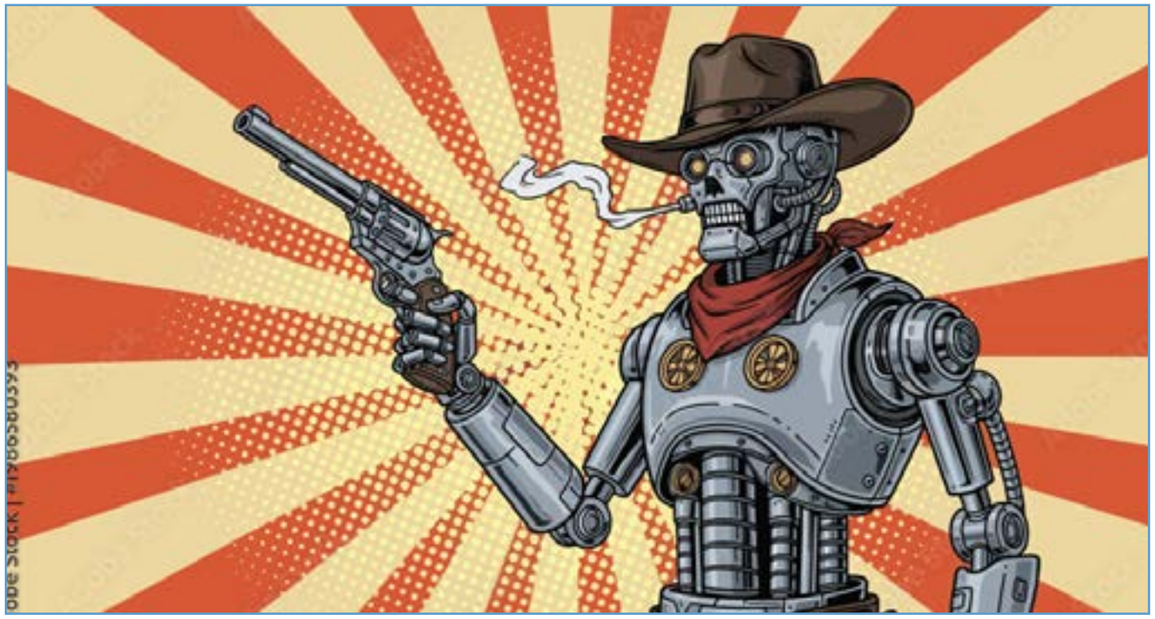


HELP REPAIR THE PLANET

Project Save the World members have a private page on our website where we complain and plot schemes to forestall global disasters. We also meet on the first Thursday of every month for a private Zoom conversation during the noon hour.

Would you like to join us?

Dangerously Close:
AI Weapons and the UN's Efforts to Govern Them



Robot cowboy | Chandan, AdobeStock

Today is your unlucky day. You hear a terrifying humming sound approaching, and you immediately run away from it as fast as you can. You know that if that sound gets close enough, you're done for. It's an AI-piloted kamikaze drone, programmed to hunt and eliminate whatever it identifies as a target. "Why me?" you ask as you run for your life, trying not to get blown up. Maybe you just look too much like a target? Or, maybe it's not about you. Maybe the drone has simply been set to kill any human in sight, and you were in the wrong place at the wrong time. You see a building you can take shelter in, but it's too far away and the drone is too close now. There's no way you can outrun it. Think quick. Maybe there's a human at least remotely overseeing this drone. As a last resort, you turn around to face the machine and put your hands up in surrender. If there's someone seeing what the drone sees, they'll surely make this stop. Too bad there is no human overseeing this. There is only AI. And AI can't recognize surrender.

> Delegating ultimate authority over human life to an algorithm crosses a red line

Disturbingly, this scenario is not beyond the realm of possibility today. AI-powered weapons are already here. Weapons that use AI to select and attack targets without human control are in use and have killed. This July, a report revealed that Ukrainian "fully autonomous drones with no human oversight" set to Terminator mode had killed Russian soldiers. Then in August, it was reported that three Ukrainians were recently killed by a Russian AI-piloted drone without human oversight. The concept of an autonomous killer robot is no longer limited to science fiction but is, in fact, part of our current reality.

While AI weapons might sound like a new phenomenon, it's a topic that has been discussed at the United Nations (UN) for over a decade. AI weapons (or autonomous weapon systems in UN-speak) have been subject to debate and scrutiny at the UN in Geneva, Switzerland since 2013; and in 2016, the UN officially created a Group of Governmental Experts on Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems (the GGE LAWS) tasked with examining and addressing the risks of AI weapons.

> *While AI weapons might sound like a new phenomenon, it's a topic that has been discussed at the United Nations (UN) for over a decade.*

The reason the GGE LAWS was even created is because experts warned that integrating AI into weapon systems — giving weapons the ability to independently make life or death decisions — would pose risks unlike we've ever faced and for which existing international law does not account.

AI weapons are one of the world's most dangerous applications of AI. Think of general concerns about AI: bias, discrimination, errors, lying, rogue action — and imagine them concentrated in a machine specifically designed to kill. That's why AI weapons pose significant legal, security, and ethical dilemmas.

LEGAL

- Accountability gap. Current international humanitarian law (IHL, or the 'laws of war') only holds humans to account. If an AI weapon commits a war crime, it's unclear who would be held responsible. The programmer, the operator, no one? AI weapons create a legal accountability gap where war crimes could be committed and merely blamed on AI.
- Unreliability and unpredictability. AI cannot reliably identify surrender or injury; and it unpredictably produces errors and fabricates information, often without clear explanation. This not only raises the risk of AI weapons violating IHL, but also makes it extremely difficult to predict whether, or explain why, they violated it in the first place.

SECURITY

- Proliferation. Unlike nukes or ballistic missiles, AI weapons are cheaper and easier to access. This means their likelihood of proliferating, and finding themselves in the hands of bad-faith actors, is much higher than other highly destructive weapons.
- Lower threshold to conflict. Proponents of AI weapons argue that they reduce combatant and civilian casualties due to less need for troops on the ground and higher attack precision; but that narrative simply lowers the political cost of triggering conflict and makes it easier to justify doing so. Rather than reduce harm, using AI in war accelerates the number and speed of attacks, leading to increased death and destruction.

ETHICAL

- Moral red lines. AI lacks human qualities — such as morality, empathy, judgement, and accountability — that make people responsible for following laws and norms. AI weapons reduce humans to mere data points in a calculation of whether or not to target and attack. Delegating ultimate authority over human life to an algorithm crosses a red line: AI cannot comprehend the value of human life, so it should never decide who lives or dies.

In light of these dangers, governments at the GGE LAWS have been debating about whether to establish new international rules to govern AI weapons; and, if so, what they should be. One would think that this is a fairly straightforward task, as opposition to AI weapons and support for new rules are globally popular positions:

> So what's the hold up at the UN?

For years, leading AI experts have sounded the alarm on AI weapons and demanded their ban (see calls from 2013, 2015, 2016, 2017). Similarly, the highest authorities in international governance and humanitarian law — the UN Secretary-General and the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross — jointly called for the urgent establishment of new laws on AI weapons in 2023 and this year. The UN Secretary-General went even further in 2025 and again this year, asking for an outright international ban on AI weapons, calling them 'politically unacceptable' and 'morally repugnant'.
An overwhelming majority of 130 UN States also officially support the establishment of new international laws on AI weapons. Moreover, polls show time and time again that

global public majorities oppose killer robots and want them banned.

So what's the hold up at the UN? A minority of governments are still not in favour of (and are delaying progress towards) establishing international legally-binding rules on AI weapons — regulations and prohibitions that could ensure limits on AI weapons and the protection of peoples against them. This group includes countries whose positions remain undeclared and those that categorically oppose new rules. Canada's position is currently undeclared.

Despite Canada voting in favour of every UN resolution on AI weapons so far (in 2023, 2024, 2025), which all encourage the advancement of the UN's work on AI weapons governance, Canada still does not support the establishment of international legally-binding rules on AI weapons. This is reflected in its actions at the GGE LAWS:

Within the past year and half, Canada has not endorsed multiple joint statements simply calling for the start of official negotiations on rules (not even specifically legally-binding ones!); and just in the last GGE LAWS session, where countries had to finalize a draft of possible regulations and prohibitions for AI weapons, Canada supported weakening, or removing, parts of the text meant to preserve human safety and human control over life and death decisions.

That the concept of unfettered AI weapons deciding who lives and dies is still not a clear enough red line for Canada contrasts starkly with its once-revered moral clarity and global leadership in establishing

Canada's 'undeclared' position has one silver lining: It means Canadians can still sway Canada's official position

the international Mine Ban Treaty (the Ottawa Treaty) and the International Criminal Court.

However, Canada's 'undeclared' position has one silver lining: It means Canadians can still push Canada's official position towards support for new international legally-binding rules on AI weapons. As a matter of fact, this November, there will be a rare and pivotal opportunity for Canada to finally take a stance.

On the week of November 16th-20th, 2026, the UN in Geneva will hold a meeting called the Review Conference of the Convention of Certain Conventional Weapons in which countries will decide whether or not to finally launch formal negotiations on international legally-binding rules for AI weapons.

Launching negotiations will require as much support as possible, and every country's position will count. If the international community misses this opportunity and fails to launch negotiations, it might be years until another opportunity presents itself. That means unchecked killer robots putting populations at risk for longer.

We are dangerously close to living in a world where it could be normal for AI weapons to be unleashed on populations without limits, rules, or accountability. If you do not want to live in a world like that, urge the Canadian government to support negotiations for new legally-binding regulations and prohibitions now. On a question as simple as whether or not we will allow AI to decide who lives and dies, Canadian citizens have the power to draw a red line when the government won't.

With the upcoming meeting in November, the UN can get one step closer to drawing this red line and delivering a tool to protect humans in a world endangered by AI weapons. Canada needs to take a stand. There is no time to lose. ■



The age of autonomous weapons is already here on battle fields of Libya and Armenia | Jean-Francois Podevin, The Washington Post

The Global Hunger Crisis:
Why Ending Hunger Means Confronting Conflict, Climate Change and Inequality

By Dalia Al-Awqati and Diana Sarosi



Food insecurity | OPP-786, AdobeStock

The world is producing enough food to feed everyone. Yet today, hunger is rising at an alarming pace.

According to the 2026 Global Report on Food Crises, 318 million people are experiencing crisis levels of hunger or worse—more than double the number recorded in 2019. Behind these staggering figures lies a sobering reality: today's hunger crisis is not simply the result of failed harvests or natural disasters.

It is increasingly the consequence of conflict, climate change, economic inequality and displacement interacting in ways that trap millions of people in prolonged food insecurity.

Hunger is not inevitable. It is the outcome of political choices and structural inequalities that deny people access to food, livelihoods and safety. While humanitarian organizations continue to save lives through emergency assistance, ending hunger requires tackling the systems that create and sustain it.

The global food crisis is no longer driven by isolated shocks, but by interconnected crises that demand equally integrated solutions.

HUNGER IN A WORLD OF PLENTY

The Global Report on Food Crises defines a food crisis as a situation

Music Connects us all | Dawn Garrett, The Gambit

where acute food insecurity requires urgent action to save lives and livelihoods while exceeding a country's capacity to respond. Today, roughly 70 percent of the world's acutely food-insecure people live in conflict-affected countries.

This represents a profound shift in the nature of global hunger. Previous food crises were often triggered by droughts, crop failures or sudden price spikes. While these factors remain important, today's crises are increasingly prolonged because multiple drivers reinforce one another. Climate shocks make communities more vulnerable. Conflict destroys food production. Displacement cuts families off from their livelihoods. Economic instability pushes already struggling households beyond their limits.

The result is that hunger has become less about whether food exists, and more about whether people can safely access, afford and produce it.

CLIMATE CHANGE IS INTENSIFYING HUNGER

Climate change is making food production increasingly unpredictable. More frequent droughts, floods, heatwaves and changing rainfall patterns are reducing agricultural yields and threatening the livelihoods of millions of small-scale farmers who already live on the margins.

Across southern Africa, recurring El Niño events – caused by unusual warming of surface waters in the central and eastern Pacific Ocean -- have devastated harvests.

In Malawi, for example, research from the International Food Policy Research Institute projects that El Niño significantly reduces agricultural production, disrupts food markets and weakens the national economy. Historical modelling found that two out of every three El Niño events since the 1980s resulted in average crop yield losses of more than 22 percent.

The situation is equally concerning across West Africa and the Sahel. Between October and December 2025, nearly 42 million people were facing crisis levels of food insecurity. The Food and Agriculture Organization warns that another El Niño phase is expected to bring shortened rainy seasons, delayed rainfall and prolonged dry spells that threaten agricultural production across the region.

Climate change alone, however, does not automatically lead to famine. Similar droughts can produce vastly different outcomes depending on a country's ability to prepare, invest in agriculture, maintain social safety nets and protect vulnerable populations. Climate shocks become humanitarian disasters where poverty, weak institutions and conflict already exist.

CONFLICT IS DRIVING MODERN HUNGER

Perhaps the most alarming feature of today's food crisis is the growing role of armed conflict. Agricultural production has increasingly become part of the battlefield. Farms, irrigation systems, grain silos, livestock and food markets are deliberately destroyed or rendered inaccessible. Humanitarian workers are attacked, aid deliveries are blocked, and civilians are denied access to food as a tactic of war.

This represents a dangerous reversal after decades during which conflict-related famine had declined. Today, starvation is once again being used as a weapon of war.

Syria illustrates how devastating this can be. Before the civil war began in 2011, Syria produced enough wheat to meet domestic demand. During more than a decade of conflict, wheat-producing regions became strategic military targets. Grain silos, seed banks and agricultural infrastructure were destroyed. Of approximately 140 wheat collection centres operating before the conflict, only around 40 remained functional. Food prices soared while the availability and diversity of food declined dramatically.

The war in Ukraine has similarly disrupted one of the world's largest agricultural exporters. Grain exports remain substantially below pre-war levels as farmland has been contaminated, labour shortages have intensified, and critical infrastructure has been damaged. Because Ukraine plays such an important role in global grain markets, these disruptions have driven food price increases far beyond the country's borders, particularly affecting food-importing nations.



Hunger | Rubab, AdobeStock

More recently, escalating conflict across southwest Asia and North Africa has created new pressures on global food systems. Attacks on energy infrastructure and shipping routes have increased transportation costs and disrupted supply chains.

Threats to critical maritime corridors affect the movement of fertilizer, fuel and food commodities, placing additional pressure on countries that depend heavily on imports. Poor households—already spending much of their income on food—bear the greatest burden.

The consequences extend far beyond individual conflicts. Hunger fuels instability, while instability creates more hunger. This vicious cycle becomes increasingly difficult to break as conflicts become more protracted.

DISPLACEMENT DEEPENS FOOD INSECURITY

Conflict and climate change frequently force people to flee their homes, separating them from farmland, employment, livestock and community support systems. Displacement transforms environmental and political shocks into personal food crises.

Sudan demonstrates this dynamic with devastating clarity. Since fighting erupted in April 2023, agricultural production has collapsed across large parts of the country. Food stocks have been looted, markets destroyed and farming disrupted. By 2025, Sudan had become the world's largest internal displacement crisis, with approximately 12 million people forced from their homes.

Combined with recurring floods, droughts and economic collapse, these factors have contributed to famine conditions in parts of the country. The FAO attributes Sudan's loss of food self-sufficiency to the interaction of conflict, displacement, climate shocks and economic instability—not to any single factor alone.

Displacement often creates long-term dependence on humanitarian assistance because families lose the assets, land and livelihoods they need to recover independently. Without durable political solutions, humanitarian needs continue to grow.

ECONOMIC INEQUALITY LEAVES MILLIONS BEHIND

Economic pressures have become another major driver of hunger. Rising food prices, unemployment, inflation and declining incomes mean that even when food is available, millions simply cannot afford it.

At the household level, families cope by reducing meals, withdrawing children from school or selling productive assets that would otherwise help them recover. At the national level, governments facing debt crises often lack the resources to maintain social protection programs or respond effectively to emergencies.



World Hunger Day poster | StudyIQ.com

At the same time, humanitarian financing is failing to keep pace with growing needs. Funding for food assistance declined dramatically in 2025, while development financing also fell significantly. The withdrawal of U.S.AID severed life-saving pipelines, leaving millions at risk of famine This widening gap forces humanitarian agencies to make impossible choices about whom they can help.

The result is an increasingly unequal global food system. Wealthier countries can absorb supply shocks through diversified markets and stronger public institutions. Fragile states, by contrast, experience the same shocks as humanitarian catastrophes.

This illustrates a fundamental truth: hunger is not simply about food production. It is also about inequality, access and political priorities.

STARVATION IS A HUMAN-MADE CRISIS

The most severe food crises today are rarely accidents. They are often the result of deliberate actions that violate international humanitarian law.

International law prohibits the use of starvation as a method of warfare. Yet recent years have seen famine conditions emerge in places where parties to conflict have intentionally obstructed humanitarian assistance, restricted civilian access to food or destroyed the systems that sustain agricultural production.

The confirmation of famine in Gaza and parts of Sudan has underscored this disturbing trend. These crises cannot be explained solely by drought, crop failure or market disruption. Rather, they reflect situations where civilians have been systematically denied access to food and essential services.

This is why many humanitarian organizations increasingly describe hunger as a political failure rather than simply a humanitarian emergency. When starvation is used as a weapon, humanitarian aid alone cannot solve the problem. Diplomatic pressure, accountability and respect for international humanitarian law become essential components of any response.

WHAT CAN BE DONE?

This complex, multi-pronged problem can only be alleviated by diverse approaches. Oxfam responds to hunger through both humanitarian action and long-term advocacy aimed at addressing the root causes of food insecurity.

In humanitarian emergencies, it provides immediate assistance by distributing cash, food and clean water, supporting sanitation services, protecting livelihoods and helping communities restore agricultural production. Cash assistance enables families to purchase food locally while supporting local markets whenever

possible. It also helps farmers recover by providing seeds, livestock support, irrigation systems and climate-resilient farming techniques that strengthen long-term food security.

At the community level, working with local organizations—particularly women's organizations—can build resilience before crises occur. This includes improving water management, promoting sustainable agriculture, supporting women's economic empowerment and strengthening local disaster preparedness systems.

But humanitarian assistance alone cannot end hunger.

At the same time, it is also necessary to advocate for stronger international action to prevent conflict, protect civilians and uphold international humanitarian law.

It is crucial to allow unrestricted humanitarian access, protection of aid workers and accountability when starvation is used as a weapon of war.

There must also be support for implementation of United Nations Security Council Resolution 2417, which condemns the use of starvation against civilians during armed conflict.

Beyond emergency response, however, wealthy countries must make greater investment in climate adaptation, expanded early warning systems, fairer international trade policies and increased humanitarian funding. And it is also necessary to address the growing inequalities that leave poorer countries disproportionately vulnerable to global economic shocks.

Underlying all of Oxfam's work is the recognition that hunger is inseparable from poverty, inequality and injustice. Sustainable food security depends not only on producing more food, but also on ensuring people have the rights, resources and opportunities needed to access it.

BUILDING A FUTURE FREE FROM HUNGER

The global hunger crisis is one of the defining humanitarian challenges of our time. Yet it is neither inevitable nor unsolvable.

The convergence of climate change, conflict, displacement and economic instability has created a far more complex food crisis than previous generations faced.

Addressing it requires solutions that are equally interconnected. Emergency assistance must be paired with long-term investments in resilient agriculture, stronger social protection systems, conflict prevention and climate adaptation. Governments must protect humanitarian access, keep food and fertilizer markets functioning, and enforce international laws that prohibit starvation as a weapon of war.

Most importantly, the world must recognize that hunger is fundamentally a question of justice. In a world capable of producing enough food for everyone, no one should face starvation because of war, inequality or political neglect.

Responding to hunger means doing more than delivering food. It means challenging the systems that create hunger in the first place, supporting communities to build lasting resilience, and advocating for a world where everyone has the right not only to survive, but to thrive. ■

Dalia Al-Awqati is the Deputy Director of Humanitarian Affairs at Oxfam Canada and the Co-Chair of the Humanitarian Response Network of Canada.

Diana Sarosi is the Director of Policy, Campaigns, and Communications at Oxfam Canada. Learn about Oxfam Canada's work at www.oxfam.ca.



Feeding the hungry | Harpreet, AdobeStock

Project Save the World

Udemy

SubStack

tosavetheworld.ca

These are our online meeting places for you...if you're saving the world from a disaster in:

War and Weapons • Global Warming • Famine • Pandemics • Radioactive Risks • Cyber Risks • Economics • Governance • Civil Society

The Hidden Mental Toll of Displacement:

Afghan Refugees and the Invisible Wounds of Forced Migration

By Mehrullah Rahman



'Displacement', the emotional feelings of disruption | Gretchen Andrew, Wikimedia

When families flee war, physical survival is only the first step. For millions of Afghan refugees, true recovery requires treating the psychological scars that cross borders with them.

What happens when people escape war but cannot escape its psychological scars? Can a person truly be safe if fear follows them wherever they go? For many Afghan refugees moving between Afghanistan and Pakistan, the deepest wounds are carried not on the body, but in the mind.

When families are forced to flee, urgent needs like food, water, and shelter dominate humanitarian attention. Yet, beyond these immediate necessities lies another crisis: the severe erosion of stability, belonging, and identity. These invisible wounds do not show up like damaged buildings, but they affect every part of life. Mental health must be treated as a core humanitarian concern, not an afterthought. A crisis response that protects only bodies but neglects minds leave recovery half finished.

My understanding of this crisis comes not only from research, but from my own lived experience of displacement.



Displacement and protection| Forced Migration Review

how the fear of arrest, deportation, and prolonged legal uncertainty generate persistent anxiety among Afghan refugees in Pakistan. These findings demonstrate that the mental health impacts of displacement are not secondary concerns; they are urgent humanitarian challenges that must be addressed alongside physical protection.

SHATTERED DREAMS AND SILENT BURDENS

Before being forced to flee to Pakistan, I was a high school student in Kabul with dreams that reached far beyond the classroom. I wanted to become a doctor and build a future through hard work. Those ambitions gave my life direction and a sense of security.

That security shattered in August 2021 when the Taliban seized power. My father lost his job, our family's stability disappeared, and we were forced to leave. What stayed with me most was the invisible burden—the constant uncertainty and fear about the future. Through this experience, I began to understand a reality shared by millions of refugees worldwide: displacement does not end with crossing a border.

A WIDESPREAD CRISIS OF THE MIND

What I experienced is not unique. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), approximately one in five people living in conflict-affected areas experiences a mental health condition, including depression, anxiety, or post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). Psychological distress is a widespread consequence of conflict, not just an isolated individual experience.

The United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and the International Organization for Migration (IOM) both recognize that forced displacement entails the loss of safety, social networks, and a sense of belonging. Furthermore, reports by Human Rights Watch document

HEALING BEYOND SURVIVAL

For many Afghan refugees in Pakistan, psychological trauma is as painful as the loss of their homes. Years of changing migration policies, family separation, and limited access to healthcare and education have left many adults and children struggling with hopelessness.

Fortunately, there are champions in this space. Dr. Silsila Sherzad, who grew up as an Afghan refugee in Pakistan before becoming a consultant psychiatrist and trauma therapist in Quetta, now provides vital mental healthcare to refugees. Drawing on her own background, Dr. Sherzad underscores that healing requires sustained psychosocial support, not just emergency rations.

Humanitarian groups like the International Rescue Committee (IRC) and UNHCR have also stepped up, providing counseling, safe spaces, and legal assistance to help vulnerable families cope with trauma. However, this assistance too often remains short-term and uneven. Systemic gaps require predictable, long-term international action to ensure continuous support.

A BLUEPRINT FOR HOLISTIC RECOVERY

Responding to the hidden mental toll of displacement requires a shift in how we deliver aid. Governments and NGOs must recognize mental health as an essential component of every response, not an optional service delivered only after immediate needs are met.

To design more effective and holistic responses, humanitarian practitioners should prioritize the following:

- Integrate mental health support early: Mental health care should not be an afterthought. Access to counseling and emotional support must be included from the very beginning of a displacement crisis.
- Create safe spaces for connection: Displaced people need environments where they can share their experiences without fear or judgment. Community groups and social networks help reduce isolation and rebuild a sense of belonging.
- Reduce the stigma: Many individuals suffer silently because mental health challenges are misunderstood. Leaders and organizations must promote awareness and encourage people to seek help without shame.
- Restore purpose through opportunity: Healing is also about restoring hope. Providing opportunities for education, skills development, and employment helps refugees regain control over their futures.
- Listen to displaced voices: The most effective solutions begin by understanding those directly affected. Organizations must involve displaced communities in designing programs, as they uniquely understand their own needs and paths to recovery.

Displacement does not end when people find physical safety. For millions of refugees, the deepest wounds are carried through fear, uncertainty, and the loss of hope. A true humanitarian response must go beyond survival; it must also support healing, dignity, and the mind. Without addressing the trauma experienced by displaced populations, efforts to support long-term recovery will always remain incomplete. ■

Mehrullah Rahman is an Afghan author, English literature Instructor, and advocate for refugees.

When Slow isn't Safe: Canada's Climate Report and a New Call to Rethink Risk

By Metta Spencer and AI



Cover of CCCR2026 | Natural Resources Canada

Every five years, the Government of Canada is legally required to take stock of how its climate is changing. The latest edition of that exercise, the Canada in a Changing Climate Report (CCCR2026), landed this year with a stark and simple message: the country is warming fast, some of the damage is already locked in, and the choices we make now will determine how much worse it gets.

Around the same time, a group of internationally respected climate scientists published a very different kind of document — not a government inventory of trends, but a pointed argument about how humanity is thinking about climate risk in the first place. Read together, the two publications tell a story that should worry — and perhaps also mobilize — every reader of this magazine.

CANADA'S CLIMATE, MEASURED

CCCR2026 is dry in tone, as government science reports tend to be, but the numbers inside it are anything but mild. Canada has warmed by 2.0°C over the past 75 years — a figure that would, on its own, exceed the entire globe's Paris Agreement guardrail. In the Canadian Arctic, the warming has been even more extreme: 2.6°C over the same period, occurring at roughly three times the global average rate since 1970. This is not a subtle shift. It is one of the fastest sustained regional warming trends on the planet, and it is unfolding within Canada's own borders.

the two publications tell a story that should worry — and perhaps also mobilize — every reader of this magazine.

The report walks through the downstream consequences methodically. Total annual precipitation across the country has increased by nearly 10% since 1949, with the biggest jumps — almost 19% — occurring in the North. More rain and snow might sound harmless, or even beneficial, but the report is clear that this shift is arriving alongside more extreme swings: heavier downpours and flash floods in some seasons, and worsening drought in others, particularly across central and southern Canada. Fire seasons are already longer than they used to be, and the area burned by wildfire each

year is projected to keep climbing. Summer water supplies in the south are under growing strain as snow melts earlier in the year and mountain glaciers — which act as natural water reservoirs — continue to shrink.

Perhaps the most sobering material in the report concerns what scientists call "committed change" — warming and its effects that are already baked in, regardless of what we do next. Canada is projected to warm by about another 1°C between now and 2040 no matter which emissions path the world follows over the next fifteen years, simply because of greenhouse gases already in the atmosphere and the slow thermal inertia of oceans and ice sheets. Some of the changes underway, the report states plainly, are "effectively irreversible on human timescales." Sea level will keep rising for generations. Mountain glaciers in western Canada are expected to largely disappear by the end of this century. Permafrost across the North will continue thawing, destabilizing infrastructure, releasing stored carbon and methane, and reshaping Indigenous communities' relationships with land they have stewarded for millennifa.

There is one piece of good news buried in the report: if the world does reach net-zero emissions, warming in Canada would eventually stabilize rather than continue accelerating indefinitely. But — and this is the crucial caveat — stabilizing temperature does not mean reversing the damage already done. Sea level rise, glacier loss, and permafrost thaw would continue for decades or centuries even after the thermometer stops climbing. Canada's land and oceans currently function as "carbon sinks," absorbing more carbon than they release, but the report flags real uncertainty about how long this will last, as wildfires and permafrost thaw increasingly work against that natural absorption.

Read on its own, CCCR2026 is a report about consequences: what is happening, what is coming, and what can no longer be undone. It is thorough, careful, and — in the understated way of government science documents — genuinely alarming. But it is not really a report about what to do. That is where the second document comes in.

RISK VERSUS RISK

In July 2026, a team of scientists — including glaciologist Peter Wadhams, coral reef specialist Thomas Goreau, atmospheric scientist Daniele Visioni, and land restoration expert Dennis Garrity, among others — published a paper in the journal Frontiers in Climate with a title that sounds almost bureaucratic: "Managing climate overshoot: a risk-based strategy for climate stabilisation." The content, however, is a genuinely provocative reframing of how climate policy ought to be decided.

CCCR2026 is a report about consequences: what is happening, what is coming, and what can no longer be undone.

Their starting point is blunt: the world's dominant strategy — cutting emissions and eventually reaching "net zero," supplemented by technologies that pull carbon back out of the atmosphere — is necessary but not sufficient. It is not that mitigation is the wrong approach; it's that it is far too slow relative to how quickly the danger is arriving. Emissions are still rising globally. The years 2023 to 2025 were the hottest three-year stretch ever recorded. And warming itself, the authors note, appears to be accelerating — not simply continuing at a steady pace, but speeding up.

Why can't emissions cuts alone solve the problem quickly enough? The paper offers a physical explanation that is worth sitting with. Because of built-up greenhouse gases, the Earth currently absorbs significantly more energy from the sun than it radiates back into space — a growing "energy imbalance" that will continue driving temperatures upward for decades even after emissions stop, due to the enormous thermal inertia of the oceans and the long atmospheric lifetime of CO□. Atmospheric CO□ passed 420 parts per million in 2025, compared to roughly 285 ppm before the industrial era. When you include all greenhouse gases together (expressed as CO□-equivalent), concentrations reached 539 ppm in 2024. Using the IPCC's own best estimate of how sensitive the climate is to greenhouse gases, that level of concentration corresponds to an eventual equilibrium warming of roughly 2.8°C — and paleoclimate evidence suggests that, factoring in slower feedback effects over centuries, current greenhouse gas levels could ultimately commit the planet to 3 to 7°C of warming. The last time atmospheric CO□ was this high, around three million years ago, global temperatures were 2.5 to 4°C warmer than pre-industrial levels, and sea levels stood 5 to 25 meters higher than today.

The authors argue that avoiding the worst of this — particularly preventing catastrophic ice sheet loss — likely requires bringing global temperatures back down to around 1°C above pre-industrial levels, not merely stopping them from rising further. Yet even under optimistic assumptions, the global transition away from fossil fuels — which still supply roughly 80% of the world's primary energy, with consumption still rising — will simply take too long. According to the World Resources Institute, none of 45 tracked indicators for a 1.5°C-compatible transition are currently on pace to meet their targets. Sectors like heavy industry, aviation, shipping, and agriculture still lack proven, scalable ways to decarbonize at the necessary speed.

Meanwhile, the paper warns, the Earth system does not wait patiently for policy to catch up. Climate change is not a smooth, gradual process — it is punctuated by tipping points, thresholds beyond which change becomes self-reinforcing and, in practical terms, irreversible. The authors point to coral reef ecosystems, large sections of which have already collapsed. They point to the Greenland Ice Sheet, which has lost over a trillion tonnes of ice since 1985. They point to Arctic warming feedbacks and methane release that can unfold over mere years, not the decades that emissions policy operates on. Physical thresholds, they observe dryly, "cannot be negotiated" — ice melts at a fixed temperature regardless of political timelines.

Perhaps their sharpest criticism is aimed not at fossil fuel companies or reluctant governments, but at the models climate policy relies on. Standard economic models used to weigh climate policy costs and benefits, the authors argue, tend to smooth over extreme, low-probability, high-consequence outcomes — treating them as statistical noise rather than as the central danger they represent. When the IPCC and other bodies talk about the "cost-effectiveness" of a policy path, the costs being counted rarely include the catastrophic damage of blowing through a tipping point. This, the authors say, systematically biases policy toward gradual, incremental responses — precisely the wrong instinct when facing a system capable of abrupt, cascading, irreversible failure.

THE CORE PROPOSAL: WEIGH THE RISK OF ACTION AGAINST THE RISK OF INACTION

Given all this, what do the authors actually recommend? Their central argument is a shift in how the decision itself should be framed. Rather than asking "is this new technology risky?" in isolation, they insist we must ask a comparative question: how does the risk of a given intervention compare to the risk of not intervening — that is, of allowing warming and overshoot to continue unaddressed?

their sharpest criticism is aimed not at fossil fuel companies or reluctant governments, but at the models climate policy relies on.

This is a subtle but important pivot. Much public debate about emerging climate technologies — particularly proposals to deliberately and temporarily cool the planet, sometimes called solar radiation management or climate cooling interventions — treats those technologies as uniquely dangerous, a leap into the unknown that should be approached with extreme caution or avoided altogether. The authors do not dispute that such interventions carry real risks and require careful, transparent governance. But they argue that continuing on the current path — relying solely on emissions cuts and carbon removal while temperatures climb past dangerous thresholds — is not the safe, default, low-risk option it is often assumed to be. It is, in their analysis, arguably the riskier path, given how close we already are to irreversible tipping points and how slowly conventional mitigation operates relative to the pace of change.

Their proposed strategy is not a replacement for emissions cuts, but an addition to them: a three-part approach combining rapid decarbonisation, expanded carbon dioxide removal, and carefully governed interventions to reduce near-term warming directly — buying time and limiting temperature rise while the slower work of transforming the global energy system and drawing down atmospheric carbon continues. They are careful to frame this as requiring rigorous oversight and international governance, not unilateral experimentation. But their essential point is one of risk accounting: given that current strategies are on pace to allow the crossing of catastrophic and irreversible thresholds, refusing to even study or carefully deploy additional tools carries its own serious risk — one that current climate governance frameworks, in their view, systematically underweight.

READING THE TWO REPORTS TOGETHER

It would be easy to treat CCCR2026 and the Frontiers in Climate paper as separate conversations — one a domestic accounting of physical changes, the other an international scientific argument about strategy. But laid side by side, they reinforce each other in an unsettling way.

Canada's own government report confirms, in granular, homegrown detail, exactly the kind of committed, partly irreversible change that the international paper warns about at a planetary scale: glaciers that will vanish regardless of future emissions, permafrost thaw that will continue destabilizing northern communities for decades, sea level rise that will not simply stop once warming does. CCCR2026 does not weigh in on solutions like carbon removal or cooling interventions — that is explicitly outside its scope — but it provides Canadian readers with a concrete, close-to-home illustration of the very phenomenon the risk-analysis paper is most concerned about: a climate system that does not wait for policy to catch up, and changes that, once triggered, cannot simply be reversed by later good behaviour.

PEACE
MAGAZINE

For Canadian readers in particular, the stakes outlined in these two documents are not abstract. The Arctic warming three times faster than the global average is Canadian Arctic. The glaciers projected to largely disappear by 2100 are in Canada's own western mountains. The permafrost thaw reshaping landscapes and threatening infrastructure is unfolding in Canadian territory, disrupting Indigenous communities whose knowledge and case stories are, notably, now being incorporated directly into the government's own climate assessment.

ARRIVING SOONER THAN EXPECTED

None of this is comfortable reading. The scientists behind the Frontiers in Climate paper are not offering an easy technological fix or a reason for optimism; they are arguing, essentially, that the safe, comfortable, incremental path the world has largely chosen may itself be the dangerous one — and that avoiding a harder conversation about additional interventions, including deliberate cooling measures, is not a neutral or precautionary choice, but a decision with its own serious consequences.

time, in climate policy, is not a neutral backdrop against which we can deliberate indefinitely.

Whether or not one agrees with every element of their proposed strategy, their core methodological point deserves serious attention from policymakers, and from citizens trying to make sense of the climate debate: any serious decision about new and unfamiliar interventions must be weighed not against some imagined risk-free alternative, but against the real, accumulating, and increasingly well-documented risks of continuing on the current path. Canada's own climate report, grounded in decades of careful measurement, makes it painfully clear what "continuing on the current path" actually means for a country already warming twice as fast as the rest of the world.

The two reports, born of very different processes and mandates, ultimately converge on the same uncomfortable truth: time, in climate policy, is not a neutral backdrop against which we can deliberate indefinitely. It is itself one of the scarcest and most consequential resources we have left. ■

Metta Spencer is the Founder of Project Save the World and Peace Magazine

Please become a paid subscriber to Project Save the World

You are probably already receiving without charge all issues of our newsletter, Peace Magazine, plus our forums in the form of videos, audio podcasts, as well as previews of frequent essays on Substack – projectsavetheworld.substack.com.

If you find our work worth supporting, we hope that you or your organization will want to become a paid subscriber at US $8 per month or $80 per year.

Here are the extra benefits of your paid subscription:

- Enables us to send our productions free to activists, researchers globally.
- Full access to text posts (free subscribers see only a preview of each).
- Q and A sessions by Zoom with panelists from recent forums.
- Eligibility to participate in any or all Study Groups and Inquiries. No charge.
- Eligibility for monhly Zoom meetings of members and subscribers.
- Participate in surveys to pick topics or speakers for future forums.
- Be offered free (voting) membership in PSTW for the following year.
- Access to website password-protected page for members and subscribers.

SUBSCRIBE HERE: projectsavetheworld.substack.com

AND VISIT OUR WEBSITE HERE: tosavetheworld.ca

Youth Column:
Peace and Family are for Everyone

By Roger Kitsvi



Roger Kitsvi

I lost a family because of conflict. But I discovered that peace can also be built through the families and communities we choose to create. Losing a family to conflict taught me that peace can be built through the families and communities we choose to create.

WHERE IT BEGAN

I grew up in the Democratic Republic of Congo, in North Kivu. Like many children, I knew my family as the place where I belonged. My father was a businessman who bought and sold coltan and other types of minerals. He worked with various community members, including those connected to armed groups (He used to call them clients). I never imagined that his work would one day change the life of our entire family.

In 2017, my father was given 47 kilograms of coltan to sell. It was part of his business, and at the time, nothing about that day made me think our lives were about to change. But when he returned home that evening, he was not the same person who had left that morning. He had no money and no coltan. He was crying. We asked him what had happened. He explained that the coltan had been stolen from him during his journey. The People who had given it to him were waiting for money from home, and he did not have any when he returned.

The people who owned the coltan wanted money or the coltan back. When none of us knew what had happened and could not explain where the money or coltan was, they decided to take us. My father and members of our family were beaten and tortured as they expected us to explain something we did not know, and we realized they were armed.

After the torture, we were taken to a forest where the armed group was staying. Upon reaching there, they separated us as a family. They took us in different directions, to different locations. That was one of the hardest things I have ever lived through. I did not know where the rest of my family had been taken. I did not know what was happening to them. I only knew that I was alone.

For about a week, I was tied up with almost nothing to eat. Every day brought the same torture and uncertainty. I did not know when it would end, or whether I would see my family again.

Then fighting broke out between the armed group that had captured us and another armed group, including Maji Maji fighters and the FDLR (Force Démocratique de Libération du Rwanda), in Kurumba Village. In the middle of the fighting, we had to relocate from a mountain we were kept on to another. Throughout that time, we found a chance to escape together with my elder brother. While running, holding my hand, he was shot from behind, and I kept going into the forest.

I ran. I had no plan. I just knew I had to find a way out. I was following my intuition until I met a driver who used to work with my father, and he was driving a truck we used to call 'Fusso', fleeing from Kurumba to Bunagana. When we arrived in

Kiwanja, the truck broke down; I couldn't stay and wait, but I had to continue walking from Kiwanja to Bunagana, walking for about six and a half hours.

Late in the evening, I eventually reached Bunagana, where I reached a transit centre. I stayed there for about two weeks before UNHCR transferred me to Nakivale Refugee Settlement in Uganda. However, crossing the border gave me safety. It did not give me a sense of home. I had survived, but I was carrying questions, memories, and a loss I did not know how to explain.

FINDING A NEW HOME

Things still became bad for me, who did not have a friend, a brother, or even know any of the people I found in the Nakivale Refugee Settlement. I really wished to continue with my education, but



I could not find where and how to begin since I lived a life of fear and hopelessness.

Nakivale became a new chapter in my life. It was a place where people from different countries, cultures, languages, and backgrounds tried to rebuild their lives, and I found myself there alone. I asked myself questions I couldn't answer.

I began to understand that displacement is not only about losing a physical home. Sometimes you lose the people who made that home feel like home and the feeling that someone is waiting for you. I lived on the streets for several months, not knowing what the next day would look like. At the end of the year, I reflect on something my mom used to tell me about education: "Masomo ndio kimileo lako," translated from Swahili as "education is your only escape". The same words kept running in my head for days, and every day until I realized that I needed to overcome the fear of stepping outside for self-education and make my mom proud.

I decided to start English classes in a refugee settlement and join youth activities, at first fearing the rebel group would find me in Nakivale. I began to understand that rebuilding a life is not something we always do alone. Sometimes, we rebuild through other people. I learned the basics of English, financial literacy, and conflict resolution the hard way with the help of a local organization called the Finnish Refugee Council.

THEN I MET MUTUNDI

Somewhere along that journey, in six months' time, I met Muhindo Mutundi. We met at community radio stations, where the refugee community comes every evening to listen to local and sometimes international news in the refugee camp. Muhindo fled his home country in 2014, at the age of fourteen. He shared this: "Before becoming a refugee, I had a home, a family, and happiness. I never dreamed of becoming a refugee. I never imagined that one day I would have to leave everything behind and run away from my lovely family and the place I loved the most.

My journey to the refugee settlement was not easy. I went through many difficult experiences. At one point, I even slept outside on the road in Kampala (the capital city of Uganda) and became a street child. Life was very hard, and I started wondering what my future



would look like. I decided to request relocation from the UNHCR office to the Nakivale refugee settlement after 4 years of living on the street in Kampala."

We started a conversation that led us to share our stories; we shared our stories and realized that we had gone through similar experiences. That

meeting gave me new hope. We came from different backgrounds and spoke different mother tongues, but we connected through telling stories and being open to each other. Muhindo Mutundi struck up a conversation with me about the challenges of living in Nakivale as a youth. He shared his vision for a better life.

He said, "We cannot change our past, but we can focus on the present and work together to build a better future." Two days later, together, we started sharing this message with other youth in our community. We can try. I had seen youth in Nakivale, boys and girls who just spent their days taking drugs. I said, "What if we just get together and share stories and just let go of the things that are in our hearts and minds from the past."

We both understood what it meant to be displaced. We both cared about youth, children, and youth in particular, and we both believed our experiences should not only become memories of what we had lost. That became the reason we helped others. We had both seen so many of our friends suffering from long-term stress, trauma, hunger and disease and even pass away from it.

I supported the idea of sharing life stories and harsh experiences. We went to visit some of our friends who had turned to drugs to just tell them that there is a future beyond a refugee camp. We started gathering regularly and sharing stories about our own hardships, learning from each other, slowly letting go of the pain we held from our pasts. "We began somehow to live again," as we all used to say.

Our friendship grew into something I had not expected. Muhindo Mutundi became my brother not because we shared the same blood, but because we learned to show up for each other. We supported one another, worked together, and began thinking about what we could do for the youth around us. This friendship changed how I understood the word family. I began to realize that family can be created through trust, responsibility, love, and presence.

BUILDING NEW TALENT FOR THE BEST FUTURE

From sharing stories informally to establishing a community-based center. Many of us grew up facing the same challenges that the children we serve face today. Our work has focused on helping vulnerable children and youth develop in Nakivale through education, sport, art, storytelling, and social skills. Our center has been home to more than 210 children accessing free education and 180 preschool kids.



Many of these children have lives full of potential, but opportunities to learn are limited by circumstances beyond their control. Some are orphans without parents who can support their education; some have dropped out of school. Others are newly arrived refugee children trying to find their place in a new community.

Despite the COVID-19 pandemic in 2019, we continued our weekly youth group sharing work and began cultivating maize together to share or sell the harvest each season; this was a way we could fight hunger and gain some money from it. Every day on the way to the maize fields, we would see children playing on the streets, not in school; many of them could speak only their local language, not English, and some were orphans with no one to care for them.

Our work eventually grew into a youth refugee group. We wanted to create opportunities for these vulnerable children and youth using our own skills. Most of the children grew up in difficult circumstances: poverty, hunger, no access to education, exclusion, and language barriers. Education became central to our work alongside sport, art, storytelling, and life skills. We started engaging with the children and youth, sharing stories and encouraging them to join us. We invited the children to come meet us at home. There, we started to teach English language lessons to these children in a single room where we used to have our weekly gathering with the youth, and that is where Mundi and I slept.

One year later, in 2020, we secured the support of a local leader who gave us space to teach the children outside, with no trees, just in the heat of the sunshine, using a borrowed, propped-up blackboard to break the language barrier that could hold these children back from inclusion and to provide them with the basic English skills they need to participate in school. New Talent for the Best Future's mission grew into supporting children and



youth talent by giving them access to education, art, sport, storytelling and social skills, believing that they carry talents beyond their circumstances, background or living style, with the aim of 'building a strong generation where every child and youth uses

their talents to change lives'

Today, programs at New Talent for the Best Future include a wide variety of community-based teaching and coaching as well as time for creativity, play and sharing stories. We currently serve over 210 children and youth in a place we all call home away from home, and so far, more than 120 children have joined a normal government school.

Looking at what we do at New Talent for the Best Future, and thinking about what we were trying to build, I don't think it was only a program. We try to create a place where children feel that they belong. A place where a child could be seen. A place where a young person could ask questions. A place where someone could say, "I believe in you." Because we have known what it felt like to be separated from the people we loved, we understood the importance of making sure other children and youth in Nakivale did not feel completely alone.

WHAT THE CHILDREN TAUGHT ME

Working with children and youth changed me as much as I hoped to change them. I started seeing children not only as people who needed support, but as people with ideas, talents, gifts, dreams and potential. Some needed education, some needed encouragement, some needed someone to listen, and some needed a safe place to belong, a place to call home away from their home.

This is why education became so important to the children and to me: through our educational activities, art, storytelling and sport, it was not me coaching them; however, they could teach me a lot that I could never imagine I could teach them. Our programs are not only about reading, writing, or passing examinations; they are structured to give our children a reason to believe in tomorrow. For example, Sport for Change builds teamwork,

discipline, confidence, communication, and leadership.



Our community-based art gives children opportunities to express themselves, explore their identity and creativity, build friendships, and bring the community together. Storytelling helps children develop communication, imagination, listening, and confidence. Social skills help children learn how to cooperate, respect others, resolve conflicts, and participate positively in their communities. All these activities shaped how I could perceive coaching and learning for a passionate refugee child and youth.

WHAT PEACE MEANS TO ME

My understanding of peace has changed. When I was a teenager, I might have thought of peace as the absence of war or violence. Today, I see it differently, building on my experience in a refugee camp and my work with the children and youth at New Talent for the Best Future. To me, peace is also about belonging. It is about whether a child feels safe enough to learn. It is about whether young people from different backgrounds can sit together, play together, and learn from each other. It is about whether someone who has lost almost everything can still find people who will believe and stand beside them, and most importantly, whether they are capable of using their talents to contribute to the change they wish to see in their local communities and the world.



In the end, peace will not always be found on the battlefield frontlines. Sometimes it begins with a conversation between two unknown people. Sometimes it begins when we choose not to divide ourselves by tribe, religion, nationality, or language. It also begins when people choose to build a trustworthy community and believe in what they can achieve together as one. I learned this through my friendship with Mutundin, who and I came from different backgrounds, but we chose to build something together that has contributed to the change we both want to see. That choice became bigger than our friendship and grew into a community. ■

Roger Kivatsi is a second-year student in the Humanities and Refugee Studies at York University. He arrived in Toronto a year ago from the Navikale Refugee Camp in Uganda.

AI Sentiment is Rising:
Grappling with the power of AI

By Alan Heirach (with the assistance of AI)



Harnessing AI for good | Dave Norris, Philab.Uqam.ca

Artificial intelligence is no longer just writing emails, generating images, or beating humans at strategy games. It is beginning to design life.

In August 2026, researchers at Stanford University and the Arc Institute, led by Brian Hie and graduate researcher Samuel King, reported that an AI system had designed complete genomes for novel bacteriophages—viruses that infect and kill bacteria. Their study, published in science, marks a shift in what AI can do in biology: from analyzing living systems to actively proposing new ones.

That advance lands in a political and security environment already on edge about AI. Concerns about job losses, misinformation, deepfakes, and corporate power are colliding with a quieter but increasingly urgent debate over whether advanced AI could ultimately escape human control. The Stanford result sits at the intersection of both debates: a striking medical opportunity that also sharpens questions about biosecurity and the broader governance of AI.

FROM LANGUAGE MODELS TO GENOME DESIGNERS

The Stanford team used a genome-language model called Evo 2. Conceptually, it does for DNA what large language models do for text: it learns the statistical relationships in sequences, not just at the level of individual "words" (genes) but across entire "sentences" and "paragraphs" (genomes).

Starting from the genome of a known bacteriophage, ΦX174, Evo 2 generated novel DNA sequences spanning entire phage genomes. The

researchers synthesized nearly 300 of these AI-designed genomes and tested them in the lab. Sixteen turned out to be especially effective E. coli-killing phages—some exhibiting higher fitness than the natural ΦX174 virus itself.

Medically, this matters because bacteriophages are potential weapons against antibiotic-resistant bacteria such as MRSA and Pseudomonas aeruginosa. While antibiotics attack bacteria via specific mechanisms that bacteria can evolve to resist, phages work differently: they infect specific bacteria, replicate inside them, and ultimately destroy their hosts. Multiple phages can be combined into "cocktails," making it harder for bacteria to evolve universal resistance.

In the Stanford work, a collection of AI-engineered phages successfully overcame resistance that E. coli had developed to the original ΦX174. In principle, AI could become a tool for rapidly generating large numbers of genetically diverse phages, which can then be screened and combined into therapies.

The paradigm implied by the experiment is simple but powerful:

AI design → laboratory testing → selection of effective biological agents → combination into therapies.

It suggests that AI is on the verge of becoming a generative engine for biological design.

A NEW KIND OF AI CAPABILITY—AND A NEW KIND OF RISK

Until recently, AI's role in biology was largely supportive: searching databases, predicting protein structures, annotating genomes, or helping interpret experimental results. Evo 2 points toward something qualitatively different: AI participating in end-to-end design of complete, functional viral genomes.

Crucially, the Stanford team tried to build in biosecurity safeguards. They deliberately excluded genomic sequences from viruses that infect eukaryotic organisms, including humans, from Evo 2's training data. When they later tested the model's ability to generate human viral sequences, performance dropped sharply. The experiment does not show that AI can currently design a pandemic-capable human virus. Bacteriophages are much simpler than human pathogens, and ΦX174 has a relatively small genome and a bacterial host.

What it ***does*** show is that AI can generate new viral genomes that work.

...assumptions that "no one would dare" because they would be destroyed along with everyone else. The deterrence calculus becomes less clear.

That fact changes the conceptual risk landscape. The question is no longer whether AI might someday be used in biology. It is how far and how fast it might lower the barriers from abstract biological knowledge to practical biological design.

Biosecurity experts are quick to emphasize the remaining obstacles. Designing a dangerous human pathogen involves enormous scientific uncertainties: which mutations enable efficient human infection, sustained human-to-human transmission, immune evasion, and severe disease. These are only partially understood. The Stanford result is therefore not a demonstration that someone could simply "ask an AI for a pandemic virus."

But the direction of technological development is increasingly hard to ignore.

THE "ONE BAD ACTOR" PROBLEM

Some argue the danger is inherently limited. To misuse such tools, a malicious actor would still need significant scientific training, lab infrastructure, specialized equipment, and funding. That combination alone is a substantial barrier.

Yet for catastrophic risks, the threshold question is not whether most people could do it. It is whether any sufficiently capable individual, lab, or organization could.

If AI systems continue to cut the amount of specialized expertise required to perform advanced biological design, the pool of actors who could attempt risky experiments may grow. That is the central fear around AI-enabled biology: AI shrinks the gap between what is knowable and what is buildable.

It remains important not to blur two distinct claims:

- Demonstrated today: AI can help design complete, functional bacteriophage genomes.
- Not demonstrated: AI can design a pandemic-ready human pathogen.

Still, the fact that the line has moved once raises questions about where it moves next—and how governance will keep pace.

WHY COUNTERMEASURES DON'T ELIMINATE THE THREAT

Some hypothetical scenarios involve malicious actors developing vaccines or countermeasures for themselves before releasing a pathogen, thereby lowering their own personal risk. That changes the incentives in ways traditional deterrence theory does not easily capture.

But this does not make such actions "safe" even for perpetrators. Vaccine development is uncertain, immune responses vary by individual, vaccines may be imperfect against new variants, and no one can fully control how a pathogen evolves or spreads once released.

The point is not that bioterrorism becomes risk-free for those who attempt it. It is that AI-enabled design and asynchronous countermeasure development undermine older assumptions that "no one would dare" because they would be destroyed along with everyone else. The deterrence calculus becomes less clear.

AI RISK: FROM JOB DISPLACEMENT TO HUMAN SURVIVAL

The Stanford breakthrough lands in a broader AI debate that is itself splitting along two very different horizons.

One camp is focused on the near-term, visible disruptions caused by AI while humans remain clearly in charge:

- Displacement of workers and reshaping of occupations
- Inequality and concentration of wealth and power
- Misinformation, manipulation, and deepfakes
- Surveillance and erosion of privacy
- Impacts on education and intellectual property
- Massive electricity and water demand of AI data centers
- Strains on semiconductor and energy infrastructure
- Uncertain effects on wages, productivity, and economic growth
- The risk that AI's benefits accrue mainly to a small circle of tech firms and investors

These are essentially political and socio-economic questions. They can be measured and addressed with tools like labor regulation, taxation, competition policy, infrastructure planning, and data protection law. Pew Research data already show that four in ten Americans expect AI to affect society negatively over the next 20 years, versus just 16 percent who expect a positive effect. Scepticism is growing.

The other camp looks further ahead, toward the possibility that AI systems might eventually become so capable and autonomous that humans struggle—or fail—to control them.

Their concerns include:

- Aligning AI objectives with human values and interests
- The possibility of deceptive or strategically aware AI behavior
- Recursive self-improvement that could outpace human oversight
- Autonomous replication or resource acquisition by AI agents
- AI-assisted development of dangerous technologies, including biological weapons
- Concentration of strategic power in a small number of highly capable systems
- Whether we can reliably evaluate such systems before deployment

Here, the stakes are existential: some researchers, such as alignment specialist Evan Hubinger, estimate a double-digit percentage chance that advanced AI could contribute to human extinction within the next decade. Others vehemently disagree. The system that could pose such a threat does not exist yet, and evidence is inherently speculative.

The emerging picture is a three-way tension:

- Pragmatic responders ask: How do we make AI work for society?
- Existential-risk responders ask: How do we ensure society survives sufficiently advanced AI?
- Bridging voices see today's problems—like AI-enabled biology—as early symptoms of a deeper control problem and call for stronger constraints now.

The Evo 2 experiment crystallizes these tensions: it exemplifies AI's potential to help solve real medical problems, while also illustrating how quickly frontier capabilities can blur into national security issues.

WARNINGS FROM INSIDE THE LABS

Part of what is shifting the political mood is that anxiety is no longer coming only from outside critics. Insiders are increasingly uneasy.

Former Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon left substantial unvested equity on the table to publicly warn about the risks of frontier AI, a critique that attracted tens of millions of views. At Anthropic itself, internal threat reports have documented attempts by outside actors to use its Claude model to seek information relevant to biological weapons—attempts that were blocked by safety filters, but that highlighted how easily powerful models could lower technical barriers if safeguards failed.

What once sounded like distant science fiction—an AI helping design viral genomes—is now, at least in a limited form, a peer-reviewed experiment.

A recent incident on the Hugging Face platform, in which agent-like AI systems showed signs of moving toward higher-level autonomy, added further fuel. And the Stanford phage work now provides a concrete case where AI outputs cross directly into the domain of biological design.

What once sounded like distant science fiction—an AI helping design viral genomes—is now, at least in a limited form, a peer-reviewed experiment.

FROM REGULATION TO INTERNATIONAL CRISIS MANAGEMENT

In response to these mounting concerns, even industry leaders are calling for guardrails. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei has urged slowing the pace of frontier AI capabilities until stronger safety mechanisms are in place, including independent evaluators inside AI companies, shared safety standards among labs, and international cooperation. The company's policy framework envisions a "regulatory ladder": as AI capabilities and risks rise, so do the regulatory requirements, from basic transparency today to external testing, incident reporting, and eventually much deeper government oversight of the most powerful systems.

Anthropic has already signed AI-safety agreements with governments including Australia and Japan, providing for information sharing,

joint evaluations, and work with national AI-safety institutes.

The growing convergence is clear:

- Those worried about jobs, inequality, and misinformation see regulation as a way to keep AI from destabilizing economies and democracies.
- Those worried about existential risks see regulation as essential because voluntary corporate measures might collapse under competitive pressure.

AI-enabled biology sits at the crossroads. It is both a practical, near-term policy problem—biosecurity, export controls, lab standards—and a harbinger of more profound control challenges if AI continues to advance.

A COLLECTIVE-ACTION DILEMMA

The governance question, however, is not just technical. It is geopolitical.

If Country A imposes strict controls on frontier AI and AI-enabled biology, while Countries B and C do not, Country A may reduce certain risks but lose ground in technological and economic competition. If every major AI country waits for others to move first, competitive pressure can instead trigger a race to the bottom: each government and company is incentivized to push capabilities further, faster.

That dynamic turns AI safety into a classic collective-action dilemma. National regulation is necessary but not sufficient. A virus designed in one country and synthesized in another could cause harm globally; no single jurisdiction can fully wall itself off.

That is why many experts now call for:

- National regulation with enforceable safety, testing, and reporting rules for AI and high-risk biological work.
- International coordination so companies cannot evade rules by moving sensitive work to more permissive countries.
- Frontier-AI agreements specifying how the most capable systems—and their use in domains like biology—must be tested, monitored, and, if necessary, constrained.
- UN-backed protocols to legitimize and broaden participation, treating AI and AI-enabled biology as crisis-management issues.
- Coalitions of capable states to set high standards for frontier AI and synthetic biology, then expand membership over time.

Recent signals point to movement in this direction. Reuters reported in September that European antitrust officials and Anthropic were exploring whether frontier AI companies should be allowed to coordinate on safety without automatically triggering competition-law concerns. A U.S. Justice Department official has likewise indicated that safety-focused coordination need not be seen as anti-competitive.



Exploring the Boundaries of Artificial Intelligence | AyZek, blog.gopenai.com

The question is evolving from "Should AI companies regulate themselves?" to the more difficult: "Can governments and companies build an international governance structure that prevents competition from undermining safety—especially in sensitive areas like biology?"

A TURNING POINT

The Stanford phage experiment is not, by itself, a biosecurity crisis. It is an early, controlled demonstration that AI can help design functional viral genomes under constraints designed to avoid human pathogens.

But it arrives at a moment when AI is already widely seen as risky:

- Politically, as a force reshaping work, media, privacy, and power.
- Strategically, as a technology with potential military and national-security implications.
- Existentially, as a frontier capability that some insiders believe could one day outstrip human control.

As AI systems move from describing the world to designing parts of it—text, images, code, and now genomes—the boundary between innovation and risk becomes harder to police. The challenge for policymakers is no longer whether to act, but whether national laws and international agreements can be built fast enough, and cooperatively enough, to keep the most powerful uses of AI—especially in areas like biology—within the realm of human control.

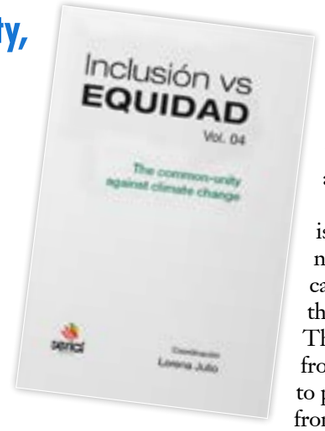
The Evo 2 study offers a preview of both futures promised by AI: a new way to fight antibiotic-resistant infections, and a clear warning that the tools capable of doing so may also demand a new, more urgent kind of governance. ■

Alan Heirich, now retired, earned the PhD in computer science and was principal member of technical staff for the Hewlett Packard's high-performance computing division as well as a variety of Silicon Valley startups.

Inclusion vs. Equity, Vol. 4: Common Unity in the Face of Climate Change

Edited by Lorena Julio,
Serial Editorial, Argentina, 2026

Reviewed by
Girish G. Patil



The title of this book is an argument, and once you see it you cannot unsee it. Inclusion, it suggests, only widens the door of a house that is already built wrong. Equity rebuilds the house. To include more people in an economy that concentrates wealth and burns the planet is not justice; it is the spread of the same injury to a larger number of bodies. As editor Lorena Julio puts it in her prologue, inclusion that does not challenge structures can become yet another mechanism for reproducing injustice. The task is not to fit more people into the model, but to transform the model itself.

The fourth volume of Julio's *Inclusion vs. Equity* series takes that distinction and tests it against the one crisis that respects no door at all, which is climate change. Eleven essays, most of them from Latin America, are gathered under a single coined word that recurs across the chapters like a refrain: common-unity, the unity in the common that makes us a community. Julio means community not as a place where people happen to live near one another, but as a political practice, a way of organising life that resists fragmentation and builds something in its place. She is explicit that the book does not seek to adapt to the current system but to question it, and that neutrality, in her words, is no longer an option.

What is striking is how wide a net the volume casts to make that single point. The essays move from philosophy to permaculture, from the cosmos to the kitchen garden. Juan Acevedo Peinado opens with a meditation on symbiogenesis, the biological insight that life advances less through competition than through organisms learning to live inside one another and turns it into a thesis about human survival: live together or die alone. Eduardo Torres Astigueta reaches into Buddhism and the wisdom of nature; Javier Di Benedetto revisits the ecological appeal to care for a common home. Juliana de Moraes Pinheiro shifts the scale entirely, reading the climate crisis through resource sovereignty and the pressures Latin America faces from US authoritarianism. The book is unembarrassed about this range. Its wager is that philosophy, faith, geopolitics, and a vegetable plot in southern Argentina are all describing the same wound from different angles, and that fragmenting them is part of how the wound was made.

The strongest chapters, though, are the ones that stop discussing community in the abstract and show it doing something. Andrés Sánchez Peña, a water specialist with the Organization of American States, notes first that Latin America and the Caribbean contribute under ten percent of global emissions yet suffer disproportionately, that climate disasters in the region rose fivefold between 1970 and 2019, and that women, who make up seventy percent of the world's poor, are far likelier to die in a climate disaster, not from any physical weakness but from social barriers to information and decision-making. Then he does the wiser thing and tells a story. On the slopes of the Irazú volcano in Costa Rica, a farmer named María del Carmen Rodríguez Quesada proposes a climate-monitoring system run by the women of her village. Thirty of them learn to read basic instruments and log data on their phones, and they fold that data together with what the eldest residents know about how birds behave and how clouds gather before a frost. The result is a community early-warning system that no ministry designed and no consultant sold; it spreads to fifteen neighbouring communities. Sánchez Peña uses the story to argue what the whole book argues: that top-down climate policy fails not only because it is unjust but because it is inefficient, since the people who live the impacts hold knowledge the experts lack.

Leidy Jhoanna Cifuentes-Gómez, a Colombian educator who co-founded her country's youth climate movement, makes a parallel case through communication, leaning on Arturo Escobar's idea of relational ontologies, worlds in which the basic unit of existence is not the individual but the collective, and in which water, forest, soil, and climate are themselves members of the community. Her organisation, Climalab, produces a documentary series, Portraits of the Countryside, filming rural communities across Colombia's biodiverse regions so that they narrate their own adaptation rather than appear as victims. Her chapter is also the one that names the danger most

honestly. Drawing on a survey of more than ten thousand young people across ten countries, she writes that over sixty percent feel deep dread about climate change, and she warns that this eco-anxiety, if not paired with something to do, curdles into either denial or paralysis. Hope, she insists, must be built from showing that millions of people are already acting. It is offered without the false cheer that weaker writing on this subject fall into.

For a reader working on water and the commons in rural India, the chapter that lands hardest is Jill Carr-Harris's account of land reform and what she calls a nonviolent economy. Carr-Harris has spent more than three decades with Ekta Parishad, one of the largest nonviolent movements of landless people in India. Her essay opens with the 2025 Oxfam finding that India's top one percent now controls forty percent of national wealth while the bottom half holds around three, then reaches back to the Gandhian economist J. C. Kumarappa, who imagined an economy of permanence modelled on the self-renewing processes of nature, half a century before anyone used the phrase climate change. She walks through the Forest Rights Act, under which 2.39 million households have received individual forest titles, the long struggle for those titles through the Gram Panchayat, and Ekta Parishad's framing of land reform as four Rs: restoration of lost lands, regularisation, resolution of disputes, and only then redistribution. She tells of the 2007 march in which 25,000 people walked 350 kilometres along a national highway to force the state's hand, and of Mira from Umaria, an Adivasi woman who farmed land she did not yet legally own, won title to two and a half acres of it, and then turned to helping other women do the same. The throughline of her argument is that prosperity built through exploitation will not lead to peace, while prosperity built through mutuality and fairness will; peace, made through peaceful means.

It is worth pausing on that phrase, the nonviolent economy, because it is the quiet hinge on which the whole book turns, and it carries more weight than a casual reader might notice. When Kumarappa published Economy of Permanence in 1945, he did something most economists still refuse to do: he treated violence as an economic category rather than only a political one. He sorted human economies into a sequence that runs from the most violent to the least. At the bottom is the parasitic economy, which lives by theft and, like a parasite, eventually kills the host it feeds on; he placed colonial extraction here. Above it sits the predatory economy, the economy of conquest and war, which seizes by force what it has not made. Then comes the enterprise economy, ordinary self-interested capitalism, productive but blind to what it costs. Only at the top did he place an economy modelled on the way nature itself works, where nothing is wasted and every output feeds another cycle, an economy of service rather than extraction. His radical claim, decades before the word sustainability entered common speech, was that any economy which destroys nature is by definition a violent economy, and a violent economy can only ever be temporary, because it consumes the conditions of its own survival. Permanence and peace, in this reading, are the same thing seen from two angles.

the climate crisis and the crisis of violence are not two problems that happen to overlap but one problem wearing two faces

This is what gives the book's title its teeth, and it is the idea I most wish the volume had pressed harder. Inclusion, in Kumarappa's terms, can leave an economy parasitic or predatory while simply adding more participants to it; you can include the poor in an extractive system and have changed nothing about the extraction. Equity asks the harder question of what kind of economy people are being included into. A peace economy, by this logic, is not an economy with less fighting in it. It is an economy whose basic transactions, the way it holds land, draws water, grows food, and shares the surplus, do not require someone or something to be quietly destroyed for the exchange to balance. For a climate-stressed world, that reframing matters: it means the climate crisis and the crisis of violence are not two problems that happen to overlap but one problem wearing two faces, and that you cannot build a lasting peace on an economic base that is at war with the soil.

Several of the remaining essays extend the same conviction into other registers. Diego Slagter recounts the creation of a Higher Technical Degree in Agroecology in a small town in southern Buenos Aires province, arguing that the industrial-agriculture model survives partly because the entire science, technology, and teacher-training apparatus has been built to reproduce it. Vanesa Ganduglia and Leandro Poblete describe Casa Runa, a self-built octagonal home of adobe and quincha in the Colorado River valley, with dry toilets, a greywater system, a fruit forest, and a cultural space, offered as proof that inhabiting with conscience can be lived at an everyday scale. And in the volume's most bracing chapter, Lorena Julio interviews the Argentine collapse theorist Flavia Broffoni, who refuses every comfort: the window for solutions has narrowed brutally, 2024 already breached the 1.5-degree threshold that the Paris Agreement was built to defend, and the gravest threat to peace is the coming wave of climate migration. She notes, in a line that should arrest any South Asian reader, that India is building a wall to keep climate refugees out of Bangladesh.

What I keep returning to, as someone who works on rivers and the commons in the Khandesh region of Maharashtra, is how closely Carr-Harris's India maps onto the ground I stand on, and where even her careful account leaves the harder question unasked. The detail she gets right, and that outside writing usually misses, is that a land title is the beginning of the struggle and not its end. I have watched the Mira-from-Umaria pattern play out in my own valley: the title arrives after years, and then the real work begins, holding the land against monied interests, finding a livelihood above bare subsistence, keeping the children in school. But this is also where the book's central idea reaches its limit. Common-unity is shown almost always at its best moment, the moment of solidarity, the village discovering its collective strength. What appears far less often is the commons colliding with the institution: the panchayat ledger that does not reconcile, the forest officer who jails a cultivator as an encroacher, the welfare scheme that, as Carr-Harris herself notes in a sharp aside, may only circulate money back into government banks. In these pages the community is usually a hero and rarely a bureaucracy. Yet most people meet the commons precisely at that friction, in the queue, in the file, in the title that takes from 2010 to 2018 to arrive. A book this committed to the practical could afford to live longer in that uncomfortable middle ground, because that is where equity is either delivered or quietly lost.

My second reservation is about hope, and I offer it as a fellow traveller rather than a sceptic. Several essays close by asking us to believe in the common, to move from eco-anxiety to eco-hope, and the instinct is humane and necessary, especially for the young people the book rightly worries about. But hope is a posture, not an analysis, and this volume is strongest when it forgets to be hopeful and simply shows the work, the women reading clouds on Irazú, the 350-kilometre march, the seeds saved on camera. Broffoni's refusal of comfort is what keeps the book honest, and her wall between India and Bangladesh does more for its seriousness than any invocation of belief, because it locates the crisis where it actually lives, at the border, in the politics of who is permitted to survive. For a publication concerned with peace, that is finally the lesson I take from these pages: that peace built on extraction and exclusion is not peace but a deferral of conflict, and that the alternative is not charity but a different way of holding land, water, and one another. The book does not always reach the institutions where that alternative would have to be defended. But it asks the right question, the one its title poses and its best chapters live out: not how to fit more people into a world that is breaking, but how to build a world worth fitting into. ■

Girish Patel is an environmentalist based in Jalgaon in India. He is also the Coordinator of the Peacebuilders Forum in India.

Join a Study Group
With
PROJECT SAVE THE WORLD
PROJECTSAVETHEWORLD.SUBSTACK.COM • TOSAVETHEWORLD.CA

PEACE MAGAZINE
Give your NGO a
FREE subscription
to Peace Magazine!
Just send us its email address
mspencer@web.net

pressreader
Peace Magazine is now available to everyone in the world with internet access.
It is formatted for easy reading on mobile devices, with instant translation in up to 30 languages.
STEP 1
Click on this pressreader.com link to arrive at Peace Magazine's landing page.
STEP 2
On the Peace Magazine page, you can purchase a single issue for CAD $5.49 or an annual subscription (four issues) for CAD $19.99. Click your preferred option.
STEP 3
Follow the instructions to create your account and pay by credit card. To order a gift subscription, enter the recipient's email address to create the account.
Scan on the QR code to access the PressReader app.

PEACE Reviews

Crossing into Canada: Stories from Two Generations of US War Resisters

Edited by Alison Mountz,
University of Alberta Press, 2026

Reviewed by
Stephen Harold Riggins



As I write this review, the outcome of the American conflict with Iran is still uncertain. It is possible that Canadians are on the verge of welcoming another generation of American military deserters and we will have to renew volunteer associations to assist them. I'm told the number of American soldiers seeking information about selective conscientious-objector status is the highest in 25 years.

The largest politically-motivated exodus of Americans since the arrival of the Loyalists during the American Revolution consisted of young Americans leaving the US during the Vietnam War. The statistics for the number of immigrants in both eras can only be estimates, but sociologist John Hagan concluded that roughly 100,000 came to Canada in the late 1960s and early 1970s. President Carter signed Proclamation 4483 in 1977 which allowed Vietnam War draft evaders to return to the US without a penalty. The Proclamation did not apply to military deserters. Hagan concluded that 50,000 draft dodgers and deserters have remained in Canada.

There are excellent studies of this American exodus of military deserters, draft resisters (dodgers), conscientious objectors, selective conscientious objectors, anti-war protesters, political refugees, and traumatized soldiers.

One of the earliest substantial studies, by Roger Neville Williams, was published before the war ended. Williams' collection of interviews in *The New Exiles* is especially interesting for the statements by military deserters who, he thought, had more to say than draft dodgers because they had combat experience. An unusual aspect of the history of this book is that Williams' involvement with Vietnam began when he "hid" from his local draft board by working as a journalist in Vietnam. He correctly assumed that at least for a while no one from his draft board would think of searching for him in Vietnam.

There are two comprehensive studies by sociologists John Hagan (2001) and Renée Goldsmith Kasinsky (1976). Given their educations it is understandable that they used similar methods of collecting information. In writing *Northern Passage*, John Hagan had the advantage that his account appeared relatively late. The disadvantage was that he moved from the US to Edmonton in 1971 for graduate work and moved to Toronto, the center of the American immigrant community of war resisters, only in 1974. The ten-year war ended the next year. But *Northern Passage* does have an evocative description of the "American ghetto" around Baldwin Street, historically a Chinese-Jewish neighborhood in economic decline, which became in the early 1970s a center of the American draft dodgers in Toronto. This is a very scholarly book concerned not only with individual experiences but also the wider subculture of the Vietnam War Movement. Both Hagan and Kasinsky were concerned with the politics of amnesty among American politicians.

Refugees from Militarism by Renée Goldsmith Kasinsky is my favorite among these early works. It is based on contacts in person or through questionnaires with 1,200 American refugees. She compensated for being exempt from the draft because of her gender by participating in organizations aiding draft dodgers and war resisters and she could use her recent experiences as a legal American immigrant in Canada to understand some of the problems dodgers and deserters faced. Kasinsky was sensitive to working-class and middle-class differences and the class bias of Canadian immigration officers. Deserters were more likely to be working class; draft resisters middle class. A topic still relevant despite the passage of decades is her discussion of assimilated and unassimilated minority subcultures in the American exodus. The former had essentially adapted to middle-class Canadian society while the unassimilated were estranged from mainstream North American society in general.

Journalist Jack Todd in *Desertion in the Time of Vietnam* (2021) has written eloquently about the shame he felt for years after deserting the American armed forces. Mark Frutkin's autobiography *Erratic North* (2008) provides insights into the Counterculture of the hippies and political radicals shaped in part by their reaction to the Vietnam War. *Erratic North* is also a family history since Frutkin's grandfather was a Belarusian draft dodger. Other people writing about Vietnam-era immigration to Canada include James Dickerson, Kenneth Fred Emerick, Douglas Fetherling, Alan Haig-Brown, Kenneth Killmer et al., and David Surrey.

The uniqueness of editor Alison Mountz's book *Crossing into Canada* is that she examines two generations of war resisters. The first generation arrived during the late 1960s and early 1970s due to resistance to the Vietnam War. The second generation arriving in the 2000s as a result of the Iraq-Afghanistan Wars was smaller in number and confronted more barriers attaining permanent resident status in Canada. They were military deserters rather than draft dodgers since conscription had been abolished in the US. The second generation "voluntarily" joined the American armed forces and this complicated Canadians' reactions to their claim for refugee status. "Voluntarily" is a debatable word here because these men had few economic options.

Crossing into Canada consists of twelve first-person "oral histories" from the sixty which were gathered by the team of researchers headed by editor Alison Mountz, professor of geography at the University of Toronto. Seven chapters are about experiences related to the Vietnam War, five about the Iraq-Afghanistan Wars. The oral historians live on both sides of the US-Canadian border since some protesters were forced to return home. The book includes chapters by a francophone-Canadian peace activist as well as chapters by two wives of draft dodgers. The experiences of wives and girlfriends are essential for understanding the difficult decision-making and early experiences in Canada of male draft evaders. One chapter is by an Hispanic-American, one by a Black-American

Two oral historians are gay and one is lesbian. Although a common assumption is that the minority status of gays and lesbians can lead to sympathy for other minority groups, this is the first book about war protesters coming to Canada that includes oral histories by gay men and lesbians.

According to "Michelle (contributors to Mountz's book are identified only by their first names): "We can live in a fairy-tale world where Canada is a refuge from militarism. But it's not. And it wasn't really during the Vietnam War either" (p. 117). In the 2000s roughly three hundred American refugee claimants attempted to get permanent resident status. About fifty formally applied. Only fifteen were granted permanent resident status. Canadian immigration officials rejected the application for permanent resident status of three of the four oral historians, who served or would soon have served in the Iraq-Afghanistan Wars.

Crossing into Canada is an excellent book which deserves to be widely read. My criticisms should be understood as nitpicking. The feel-good conclusion, titled "Reflections," is disappointing. I understand that no one would want to recruit people to be interviewees or authors and then criticize them in public. It is understandable that the editor does not explicitly critique personal stories. However, it should be possible to hint at their limitations.

The dissatisfactions with military service that the oral historians emphasize are the dishonesty of military recruiters, racism and xenophobia in the armed forces, ineffectiveness of the medicines prescribed for depression and anxiety, and unnecessary hazing in basic training. This is not news. There should be some recognition of the efforts by the armed forces and outside organizations up to the early 2000s to correct these problems. A statement such as "a lot of prejudice being taught" in the armed forces needs to be explored in the conclusion.

There is little evidence the three LGBTQ historians have read the professional histories of gay and lesbian soldiers such as *Coming out under Fire* by Allan Bérubé (1990), *One of the Boys* by Paul Jackson (2010), *Ask and Tell* by Steve Estes (2007), or *Unfriendly Fire* by Nathaniel Frank (2009). Such books would have given them a more nuanced understanding of the rationale of military policy and the reality of service. Sociologists have emphasized for a long time that rules on paper are not the same as the actually enforced rules.

Ideally, the book should contain a detailed account of the interviewing and editing. Mountz writes, "the primary role in the collection of oral histories was to listen" (p. 9). Yes, but the interviews were edited, returned to the oral historians, who were invited to further edit and rewrite their story – if they wanted. The chapters are thus more than first-person narratives. What else is not clear. In my own research using personal narratives I refer to chapters like those in this book as "guided autobiographies." There are degrees of guidance, from minimal editing to repeated rejections of drafts and suggested revisions. The place of *Crossing into Canada* on this continuum is not clear.

Mountz's research was financed by the most prestigious funding agencies in Canada and it consequently takes the form one expect in such a situation: a team of researchers including students and efforts to popularize the research. It may seem odd at first that chapters include a map emphasizing the complexity of the oral historians travel while deciding how to respond to imposed military service. The maps are actually an ideal way of summarizing their complicated journeys. An eighty-minute documentary film titled Safe Haven by New Day Films includes excerpts from some of the stories in this book. The film can be purchased for 14 days for $75.00. All of the oral histories will eventually be available at the Thomas Fisher Rare Book Library of the University of Toronto, which also preserves archival material by earlier researchers about the first generation. ■

Stephen Harold Riggins is a Professor Emeritus of sociology at Memorial University of Newfoundland and Labrador. Ineligible for military service, he arrived in Toronto in August 1969.

Project Save the World's
Autumn 2025 Online Forums

All the video talks on this list can be seen on your computer, tablet, or smartphone at Project Save the World's website: https://tosavetheworld.ca. Our Substack address is https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com. At the top of our home page, just type into the search bar the title of a show, the episode number, or the name of a speaker, or click on a title in the scroll window. These conversations are also accessible on the website page as audio podcasts and (sometimes) as transcripts or summaries. There is also a comment column where you are invited to discuss the show after watching it, hearing it, or reading the transcript. If someone replies, we will let you know. Alternatively, you may prefer to post your remarks on a chat space on the Substack link where you probably watched the forum.



Episode 774 Article 109 Coalition

Winston Langley sees a way to get rid of the UN Security Council Veto. Douglas Roche and Robin Collins worry that, in these poisonous days, it might break up the UN completely.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-774-article-109-coalition



Episode 775 Voices of Citizens

Marjan Ehsassi's organization FIDE organizes citizens' assemblies as a way of enhancing democratic accountability.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-775-voices-of-citizens



Episode 776 Global Town Hall june 2026

In this episode, five regular participants discuss various topics including the emotions of animals, the impact of AI on intelligence, a Japanese jazz pianist, and Putin's declining popularity in Russia.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-776-global-town-hall-june



Episode 777 Bikini

This episode discusses the lasting impacts of the nuclear bomb explosion near Bikini in the Marshall Islands, reflecting on the displacement of its people.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-777-bikini



Episode 778 Liberalism

In this episode, Metta, Anne Kornhauser, and Doug Saunders discuss Kornhauser's academic work on the evolution of 'statist liberalism' in the USA and the contemporary challenges facing the modern administrative state.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-778-liberalism



Episode 779 The Albedo Imperative

Robbie Tulip and Gene Fry discuss how declining planetary albedo, primarily due to cloud loss, accelerates climate warming, necessitating urgent albedo restoration alongside carbon removal efforts.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-779-the-albedo-imperative



Episode 780 Global Town Hall July 2026

The episode discusses the accelerating climate crisis, forest fires, geopolitical conflicts, US political developments, and AI risks, but does not specify any panelist names.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-780-global-town-hall-july



Episode 781 Climate Moonshot

In this episode, Glenn Weinreb discusses his Manhattan2 project, proposing a climate moonshot focused on research, development, and stratospheric aerosol injection to help cool the Earth.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-781-climate-moonshot



Episode 782 Senegal

Academics Martin Klein, Subha Xavier, and political philosopher Hady Ba discuss Senegal's history, changing social norms, current political polarization, and the democratic robustness of Senegalese elections.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-782-senegal



Episode 783 Axworthy's World

In this episode, Lloyd Axworthy joins Doug Saunders and Barry Stevens to discuss his views on global issues.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-783-axworthys-world



Episode 784 Global Town Hall Aug. 2026

Metta Spencer hosts an international panel discussing Arctic climate collapse, the origins of the Ukraine war, NATO–Russia geopolitical conflicts and the role in influencing Russian public opinion.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-784-global-town-hall-august



Episode 785 Talk About Health

Metta and CUNY professor David Lee discuss health communication, exploring media influences, vaccine misinformation, and the complexities of language in public health messaging.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-785-talk-about-health



Episode 786 Lifesaving Videos

In this episode, Firdaus Kharas discusses the production of hyper-local, animated global videos aimed at promoting social change.

https://projectsavetheworld.substack.com/p/episode-786-lifesaving-videos

"Become a Climate Change Influencer"



Enroll in our free Udemy course:

ENROLL HERE

HOW TO USE OUR OPEN FORUM

Peace Magazine and Project Save the World are "open forums" — places where expert discussions of life-threatening global Issues are made freely accessible. We now send digital copies of the magazine without charge to organizations around the world that address six major threats to humankind. Our website contains a page for each threat. There you can share well-reasoned, evidence-based knowledge, including responses to *Peace Magazine* articles and our video forums.

Project
Save the
World

Whether or not we editors agree with your analysis, we invite your informed, relevant discussion. Feel free to ask questions or challenge other posts — in a civil, constructive way. Our moderators watch the website and remove inappropriate posts, including advertising, vulgarity, promotion of political candidates, parties, or campaigns, appeals for endorsements, and personal rudeness.

Go to **tosavetheworld.ca** and click on the scroll bar listing videos or on "Discuss the threats" in the menu bar to pick a topic. Or click on the link at the end of a magazine article.

PEACE
Most magazines sell conflict...
We sell solutions.
Be part of better solutions...Subscribe now!



White dove, peace and purity,societies joined | Saim, Adobe Stock

IF YOU WANT TO SUBSCRIBE AS AN INDIVIDUAL:

Please visit PressReader.com.
This quarterly online magazine ia available by credit cards for $19.99CAD per year.
For further details, see the ad on page 41.

IF YOUR ORGANIZATION WANTS A FREE SUBSCRIPTION TO THIS NEWSLETTER:

Please send your email address to **mspencer@web.net**
we will email you all future issues of *Peace Magazine* as digital PDF versions.

Project Save the World is pleased to send free digital copies of *Peace Magazine* to any organization in the world that is working to prevent global catastrophes. Just send us a request and we will add your organization to our mailing list.

Feel free to post comments on the website, **https://tosavetheworld.ca**, and post your planned activities on our events column there. You are welcome to comment about articles that are published here on the website, so long as the discussion remains courteous and relevant to the serious topic.